Encouraging Exploration in Themed and Immersive Spaces

Understanding Experience Design Through Two Finnish Case Studies

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Abstract

Themed and immersive experiences are rising in popularity in different sectors, such as entertainment and education. This thesis explores how themed and immersive spaces can be designed to offer more opportunities for further audience engagement, as well as encouraging guests to be curious and active participants. Discovery and interactions can not only create memorable moments, but make the guests feel more connected to the experience and care about its content.

The study includes interviews with two industry professionals from two different themed and immersive experience sites. These sites, the Moominworld theme park and the Courage, Freedom, Love! exhibition are also observed as a part of the study to collect further information of guest behavior and experience design. The literature used in supporting the analysis of the collected material comes from multiple fields of research such as anthropology, performance studies and game studies to account for the multidisciplinary nature of themed and immersive spaces.

The results of the study show that designing for discovery and encouraging exploration culminates in including as many opportunities as possible and managing the guests' expectations in terms of time spent in the space and the number of things there is to see. Within the space, especially visual and audio cues are used in guiding guests' movement, though some of them are dependent on previous knowledge of the fictional world the space is representing.

Keywords

Experience design, immersive, audience engagement, theming

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1. Introduction

Who would not have imagined themselves visiting a fictional world they have encountered in books or films and dreamed of exploring the fantasy lands on their own terms? One way to do this would be to play a video game and experience the fantasy through a digital character. However, there are attractions that allow their visitors to act out this dream in the physical realm as well. Themed and immersive spaces can be used to bring fantasy lands alive, but also to re-enact historical scenarios and enable people to travel to new places without ever really leaving the country.

These spaces, whether in museums, theme worlds, or historical sites, all act as a part of the rising experience economy. Experiences, as defined by Pine and Gilmore, are "memorable events that engage each individual in an inherently personal way."[1] The case studies in this thesis fall within the art and entertainment sector, which is strongly present in the previous research done on design in themed and immersive spaces. Still, staging experiences is not unique to the entertainment industry, though they have always been at the heart of it.[2] As was noted by Pine and Gilmore, experiences do not rely exclusively on entertainment, and instead entertainment is only one aspect of an experience.[3]

Since the late 1990s the themed spaces have been the subject of widespread analysis and academic criticism, as well as a popular source of entertainment.[4] Similarly, attractions built around pop-culture, and theatrical events that break the fourth wall to allow the audience to curate their own journey through the storyline are rising in popularity. [5] These elements

[1] Joseph B. Pine Ⅱ and James H. Gilmore, "Experience Economy: Past, Present and Future," *Handbook on the Experience Economy*, edited by Sundbo, J. and Sørensen, published by Edward Elgar, (2013): 26. https://www.researchgate.net/publication/260917972_The_experience_economy_past_present_and_future.

[2] Joseph B. Pine Ⅱ and James H. Gilmore, *The Experience Economy – Work Is Theatre & Every Business a Stage*. (Harvard Business School Press, 1999), 2.

[3] Ibid., 3.

[4] Lukas, *A Reader in Themed and Immersive Spaces.* (ETC Press, 2016): 3.

[5] Ibid., 4.; Carly Markkanen, "This Is Your House: Audience Engagement Approaches in (Finnish) Immersive Theatre" (Master's thesis, Sibelius Academy, University of the Arts Helsinki, 2024), 1, https://urn.fi/URN:NBN:fi-fe2024081665244.

together are the building blocks to many themed and immersive experiences, including those chosen as the case studies for this thesis.

The aim of this study is to recognize and contextualize design elements used in Finnish themed and immersive experiences through two case studies to gather information on the practices to encourage audience engagement, interaction, and exploration. The chosen cases for are the Moominworld theme park in Naantali, and the Courage, Freedom, Love! exhibition at the Maritime Museum of Finland in Kotka. The goal is to discover information that can later be used in designing spaces that support education or leisure in a way that increases the audience's agency and immersion, which benefits multiple end goals including education, preservation, and inspiration. As the experience economy continues to grow, it is crucial that research is carried out in countries that have not traditionally been at the forefront of design for themed and immersive spaces.

The start of the experience expansion we have experienced during the past few decades can be traced back to Walt Disney, who also envisioned Walt Disney World that opened in the United Stated after his death. While it is now facing more competition than during its opening, it is still a very prominent figure in the world of themed and immersive attractions.[6] Partially due to the prominence of Disney, and the newer Universal Studios theme park, which has locations in China and Japan in addition to the United States, much of the research done on these types of attractions is centered around the United States and other countries with large theme worlds. In comparison, there is much less research done on the topic within Europe. Especially the development of theme parks has been slower in the Northen Europe due to small populations and climatic limitations.[7] This study will focus on the two case studies located in Finland to fill in this prominent gap by focusing on themed and immersive attractions in Northern Europe, and Finland specifically.

Work done by experts such as Scott A. Lukas provides a great framework for a deeper understanding of the functions, engagement styles, and purpose of themed and immersive

[6] Pine and Gilmore, "*The Experience Economy*," 3.

[7] Stephen Wanhill, "Creating Themed Entertainment Attractions: A Nordic Perspective." *Scandinavian Journal of Hospitality and Tourism*, 2. 123-144. (2002): 127. DOI: 10.1080/15022250216291.

spaces.[8] However, not much has been written about how an audience can be prompted to explore these immersive environments further. It is understood that theming and immersion help audiences connect with the space.[9] To add to this knowledge, this study will focus on the specific strategies of encouraging the audience to be active participants and interact with the spaces more freely to discover more of what is on offer.

When it comes to the use of actors in these spaces, some studies have been conducted on non-player characters in live action role play, and the role of a performer, as well as their relationship with the audience within an immersive performance.[10] This study will look at how actors can be used in encouraging guests to interact with a storyline and a space even when they are not there to actively play, as would be the case in live-action roleplay, nor to see a show, like they would with immersive theatre. Understanding how actors can be used as a tool for immersion and guidance without breaking the illusion of a fictive world can provide valuable insights into how the interaction between in-character staff and non-player visitors can be utilized to provide deeper connection to the experience and help connect the guests to the story on a more personalized level.

As the field of themed and immersive experiences is broad and interdisciplinary, the first part of this thesis will focus on defining the terminology and crucial frameworks needed to better understand the subject matter. It will then, through the chosen case studies, focus on the elements that can be used in encouraging audiences to explore these spaces and therefore create additional value for their own experience through interaction and discovery. This information will mainly be gathered through interviews and observations. It will then be analyzed with the support of existing frameworks and concepts which will be presented in chapter 2. Finally, the study will aim to recognize needs for further research that needs to be done around the subject based on the new insights or possible gaps left by this study.

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[8] Lukas, *The Immersive Worlds Handbook*. (Focal Press, 2013), 4.; Scott A. Lukas, "Why Immersion Matters" *CLADbook*, 1 (2017), https://www.academia.edu/30779366/Why_Immersion_Matters.

[9] Ibid., 138.

[10] Jaakko Stenros, "Between Game Facilitation and Performance: Interactive Actors and Non-Player Characters in Larps." *International Journal of Role-Playing*, no. 4 (2023): 76–93, https://www.researchgate.net/publication/370858606_Between_Game_Facilitation_and_Performance_Interactive_Actors_and_Non-Player_Characters_in_Larps.; Machon, *Immersive Theatres: Intimacy and Immediacy in Contemporary Performance*. (Bloomsbury Publishing, 2017).; Rose Biggin, *Immersive Theatre and Audience Experience: Space, Game and Story in the Work of Punchdrunk* (Palgrave Macmillan, 2017), DOI: 10.1007/978-3-319-62039-8.

While the original assumption was that this study would focus mainly on the physical environment and its cues, such as signs and in-character staff, it became apparent that the rules of social engagement and expectation management influence the guests' level of immersion and willingness to engage on a much larger scale than was expected.

1.1. Author's Perspective

How do you design a space that transports the guest to something other than itself?

This thesis rose from the curiosity I had towards fictional worlds becoming reality in experiences built around storylines both well-known and tailor-made. I have worked as a scriptwriter creating new stories and narratives but got increasingly drawn towards bringing them alive – and not just in a film or on a stage. I got the chance to work with designing and operating immersive escape rooms, which led me towards what I now know to call immersive entertainment.

During my film and media studies, I got interested in experiences that surrounded you and transported you into another universe, whether it be a completely new one or a version of the one we live in. I had gotten the chance to work with similar design at the escape room company but found myself missing the freedom of unstructured exploration and discovery without a time limit. At the same time, I worked as an actor in immersive and interactive performance and continued writing stories and creating worlds. All of it had an underlying feeling of floating in a space between the real and the fictive that I kept chasing time after another.

I applied to study curating to understand the creation of those moments of freedom and excitement that I experienced when wondering among lit up ghosts in the garden of an old mansion, working the hallways of a haunted house, or running through the narrow streets of a Christmas Market. Not only was I free to explore, for a moment I was free of the everyday world. When it came time to choose a topic for my thesis, I found my chance to understand what created those moments and truly understand what had drawn me into curatorial studies in the first place: themed and immersive experiences.

To me, experience design is one of the main pillars of my curatorial practice. The possibilities are endless, so how do you know which elements to choose to create something meaningful that will provoke the thoughts and emotions intended? The guest is in the focus but how can a space be designed for an individual that the designer has never met, especially if it leans heavily on immersion or interactive elements that make it even more personalized. I am hoping that by looking at two very different experiences, an exhibition and a theme park, I can find some of the elements that they share, which will hopefully be ones that can be scaled into other experiences as well, regardless of the medium.

By creating this text, I am aiming to provide tools and thoughts to others working with experience design regardless of their field, resources, or education. Therefore, my intention is to write it in a way that is also accessible to people coming from outside of the curatorial practice and outside of academia. This way I hope to be able to share my findings with as many people as possible, start conversations around the elements of immersion and exploration, and see how they can be used to create meaningful memories for all.

1.2. Aims and Research Questions

This study aims to understand methods used in the design of themed and immersive environments to gather insights on how a space can invite its visitors to explore and discover its contents rather than being satisfied with a more passive approach. It will draw ideas and concepts both from the interviews and observations, as well as existing literature within multiple fields to create a more comprehensive idea of designing themed and immersive experiences with a focus on engagement and exploration.

The study will not only focus on physical design elements but will also consider things such as staff and the guests themselves. In the future, this information can be helpful in designing attractions that encourage exploration and curiosity, whether it be in service of education or leisure.

The main research question for this study is:

- What design elements can be used to create themed and immersive experiences that offer most opportunities for interaction and encouragement for further engagement through exploration?

During the process, the following questions will also be considered since they are expected to become relevant as the study progresses:

- How can different age groups be considered when designing these spaces?
- How can in-character staff be used in encouraging the guests to explore their surroundings?

1.3. Methodology

This study is based on qualitative research and the two main methods used in the data collection are semi-structured interviews and observation. Because research in themed and immersive spaces is fundamentally interdisciplinary, this study will also use theories and findings of multiple disciplines, the main ones being anthropology, game studies and experience design. By combining findings from these areas of research allows for a more comprehensive understanding of the different elements of theme and immersion design that are required to create these types of attractions, of which the two case studies in this paper will be examples of.

This study is carried out through methods of qualitative research, which offers tools to understand experiences and perceptions.[11] Qualitative methods were chosen due to the centrality of subjective experiences and the need to understand the quiet knowledge gathered by industry professionals. Qualitative research fits especially well to exploring this type of phenomena that are complex and context rich.[12] It involves gathering non-numerical data and

[11] Weng Mark Lim, "What Is Qualitative Research? An Overview and Guidelines." *Australasian Marketing Journal*, 33(2), (2024): 200. https://doi.org/10.1177/14413582241264619.

[12] Lim, "What Is Qualitative Research?" 200.

is often used in the humanities.[13] It does need to be noted, that qualitative research does not provide purely objective data.[14] However, due to the themed and immersive experiences that are the subject of this study also being personalized in nature, the opportunity to better understand human perspective and the planned perception of these attractions is beneficial for the goals of the study.

None of the text in this thesis has been generated by artificial intelligence. Artificial intelligence has only been used for spell-checking and formatting citations, both of which have then been manually confirmed.

1.3.1. Semi-structured Interview

Interviews are often particularly helpful for research aiming to gather information about ideas and experiences over numbers.[15] They are the most often used method of data collection. Additionally, the semi-structured interview format, which is also used in this study, is the most used interview techniques within qualitative research. [16]

In semi-structured interviews the interviewer can follow a general plan and a set of questions, but they also have the freedom to make changes and be a little more creative in the interview situation.[17] Because the two case studies are somewhat different, it did not make sense to stick to the exact same questions for both interviews. The questions were instead tailored to fit each case while still addressing the same topics. As the goal of the interviews is to gather knowledge from the interviewees, the ability to ask follow-up questions and let their information shape the conversation is crucial for the best result.

This study includes separate interviews with two industry professionals to find out the knowledge they have gathered during their careers and specifically understand their thinking

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[13] Chinyere Ugwu and Val Eze, "Qualitative Research." *IDOSR Journal of Computer and Applied Sciences*, 8(1), (2023): 20.

[14] Lim, "What Is Qualitative Research?" 200.

[15] Ugwu and Eze, "Qualitative Research," 26.

[16] Hanna Kallio, Anna-Maija Pietilä, Martin Johnson, and Mari Kangasniemi. "Systematic Methodological Review: Developing a Framework for a Qualitative Semi-Structured Interview Guide." *Journal of Advanced Nursing* 72 (12), (2016): 2955. https://doi.org/10.1111/jan.13031.

[17] Ugwu and Eze, "Qualitative Research," 26.

around the two case studies. The interviewees are Ida-Maria Lohikoski, a producer at Moominworld, and Alexander Reichstein, the exhibition architect for the Courage, Freedom, Love! exhibition. Both interviews are conducted as one-on-one semi-structured online interviews.

Both interviews were done through Teams with webcams. They were conducted in Finnish to allow for clear communication and industry specific terminology to be used without a risk of it getting lost in translation during the interview. Both interviewees were informed of the interviews being a part of a master's thesis and were asked for their permission for the interview material being published as well as for their names to be included in the study.

The interviews were transcribed, during which the content of the interviews was not modified apart from the removal of filler words and repeated or incomplete phrases resulting from casual verbal communication. The transcription was first made by Microsoft's automatic transcription program through the Teams platform, but all text was then proofread, fixed and fact checked.

1.3.2. Observation

The second main method of this study is observation carried out in both locations of the two case studies. It is, alongside semi-structured interviews, one of the most common data collection methods within qualitative research.[18] In observation, the data collection is done through "keeping an eye on individuals, events, or taking note of physical traits as they occur in the wild".[19] This study uses covert observation, which means that the subject of observation is not aware of being watched.[20]

Both case studies included in this thesis were observed in two sessions. For Courage, Freedom, Love! these sessions were carried out during separate days, and for Moominworld they were done within the same day with a break in the middle. While it was not the optimal solution to have these two sessions for one of the case studies during the same day, it was

[18] Omolola A. Adeoye-Olatunde and Nicole L. Olenik. "Research and Scholarly Methods: Semi-Structured Interviews." *Journal of the American College of Clinical Pharmacy* 4 (10), (2021): 1358. https://doi.org/10.1002/jac5.1441.

[19] Ugwu and Eze, "Qualitative Research," 25.

[20] Ibid.

inevitable due to logistical reasons. The staff of neither of the location was not informed of the observation beforehand to avoid changes in their behavior.

During the first observation session the focus was on the environment, its visuals and how I intuitively reacted to the environment as a guest. For this part, the process relied on participant observation. In participant observation the researcher becomes a part of the context, and for it to be possible, they must be a member of the culture being studied, which in this study was the case.[21] In this first session I followed along with the other visitors, interacted with the space as intended, and took contact with staff members and other visitors when natural.

During the second session the focus was on observing the audience and staff, and how they interacted with the environment and one another. This second session was more focused on direct observation, which means that the researcher tries to be as unobtrusive as possible to avoid influencing the observation.[22] For this second session, I did not initiate contact with other audience or cast members and attempted to blend in as much as possible. It does need to be noted that especially in the smaller exhibition space the presence of another person in the room can affect other guests' behavior even without direct contact.

1.3.3. Case Studies

The two case studies chosen for this thesis are Moominworld in Naantali, Finland and Courage, Freedom, Love! in Kotka, Finland. A case study can involve multiple data sources, such as interviews, observations or documents.[23] This study aims to understand the elements of immersion as well as encouraging engagement and exploration within these physical locations mainly by talking to experts working on them and observing guest behavior.

This thesis is done as a multiple-case study. A multiple-case study aims to compare cases to identify patterns, relationships and similarities, and the cases chosen for it may be either

[21] Ugwu and Eze, "Qualitative Research," 25.

[22] Ibid.

[23] Hayden Coombs. "Case Study Research Defined [White Paper]." *Zenodo*, (2022): 1. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.7604301.

similar in nature, or diverse.[24] In this case, the two cases share a subject, as they both are created around Tove Jansson's Moomins. However, one of them is a theme park built around the Japanese animation created around the original works, and the other one is an exhibition taking its source materials from the original works only.

A case study looks into contemporary phenomenon in its real-life context and is often used as a method to cover contextual conditions that the researcher finds highly pertinent to the phenomenon that is the subject of the study.[25] This thesis is carried out as a case study due to the context of these environments being inseparable from the subject of the study: the design elements and audience interaction within them.

1.3.4. Author's Positioning

Due to the nature of observation as a method, it is important to recognize my own positioning in relation to the two experiences: Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love!. Previous knowledge does inevitably shape the way they are observed, even if it is paid special attention to. This will also be the case for anyone else experiencing these spaces.

Moominworld is familiar to me since many years back, as it was the annual summer holiday destination for my family that holds a fondness for the Moominvalley and its inhabitants. The park has gone through some major changes since then, including the removal of Moominpappa's boat, an attraction that many of my memories relate to, as well as the addition of multiple new characters that were not present in the park during my childhood summers. Nonetheless, they have left me with a mental map of the area and its functions, although the experience of navigating the space is different to an adult traveling alone compared to a child traveling with both parents and a younger sibling while being guided through the island and negotiating with the other members of the family.

Although Courage, Freedom, Love! was previously exhibited at the National Museum of Finland in 2020-2021, I had had not seen it in person before. It came to my attention through a connection to the exhibition architect Alexander Reichstein, whom I had interviewed previously for a school assignment, and whose earlier work I was previously familiar with.

[24] Coombs, "Case Study Research Defined," 2.

[25] Robert K. Yin. "Case Study Research: Design and Methods." *Sage Publications*, 3rd ed. (2003): 13.

Courage, Freedom, Love! was brought up during a studio visit. At the time, it was not clear the exhibition would become such a big part of the thesis process, which had only just started, so the discussion was not done in a matter preserving objectivity for observing the space later. Instead, I learned about the exhibition's design and details, many of which may have otherwise gone unnoticed during the observation period.

This tendency for guests not to see everything during a visit also came up as an important element of the exhibition, and Moominworld, which is why it is important to note that my personal observations of them are influenced by the pre-existing knowledge. However, this allowed for further observations in terms of seeing how other people reacted to these elements, or whether they were noticed at all.

1.3.5. Delimitations

This thesis faces many of the limitations known to be applicable to studies relying on qualitative research methods. A small sample size, which this study also has, limits the generalizability of the results, and the interpretive nature of qualitative research makes it more vulnerable to research bias.[26] This will be combated by paying special attention to possible biases when working with the material, and especially during the process of gathering it, to ensure that pre-existing associations and memories have a minimal effect on the observation phase of the study.

During the observation, special focus must be paid on the objectivity of the research, especially during the earlier sessions where I will focus on my own reactions to the environment. Getting too involved in the research may lead to losing objectivity, which can compromise the study's reliability.[27] However, in this case the reactions will also serve as a sample of how an adult may react to these experiences. As stated before, I am very familiar with the Moomin franchise and have visited Moominworld numerous times as a child, which will likely guide some of the observations even with heightened awareness. As these kinds of experiences are individualized and personalized by definition, pure objectivity is impossible to achieve. Instead, as long as my positioning is recognized, it can be used as an asset for the purpose of this thesis.

[26] Lim, "What Is Qualitative Research?" 203.

[27] Ugwu and Eze, "Qualitative Research," 26.

Notes were continuously taken throughout the two sessions, especially during the latter observation phases focusing on other audience members and staff. Taking notes in public spaces can be difficult without exposing oneself as a researcher.[28] It is possible that the behavior may affect the staff or audience reactions around the researcher if their behavior seems strongly out of place, which is why it needs to be recognized as a possible limitation.

1.4. The Cases from the Moominvalley

This study focuses on two case studies: the Moominworld theme park in Naantali, Finland and The Courage, Freedom, Love! exhibition in Kotka, Finland. While themed and immersive environments can be used to create historical environments, purely educational spaces, and other experiences relying on non-fictive source material, both cases chosen for this study are built around a fictive world based on the Moominvalley created by Tove Jansson.

In both destinations, the guests are able to visit known places or even specific buildings and scenes from the Moomin stories. While, for example, in an escape room or a re-enactment the audience might adopt a specific role for the duration of their experience, that is not the case for these two. While it is possible for them to create their own story or choose to play a character for the duration of their visit, they are not given one by the destination as might be done by an escape room. Especially in Moominworld, the visitors have the opportunity to visit the Moominvalley almost as tourists would visit a non-fictional site.

1.4.1. Moomins

The first images and stories of Moomins were created by Tove Jansson in the 1940's. [29] Moomins are white, furry characters sometimes described as ones resembling a hippo, although the Moomin characters themselves would oppose that description.[30] They live in a Moominvalley together with many other creatures that frequent the stories written and illustrated by Jansson. The first known Moomin character was drawn on the wall of an

[28] Ugwu and Eze, "Qualitative Research," 26.

[29] Paul Savage and Janne Tienari, Moomin Management: Redefining Generosity (Policy Press, 2024): 2. https://doi.org/10.1332/policypress/9781529240177.001.0001.

[30] Moomin, season 1, episode 20, "Muumipeikko pelastaa tiikerit," written by Akira Miyazaki, DVD.

outhouse.[31] The first book about Moomins, The Moomins and the Great Flood, was published in Finland in 1945 in Swedish, and soon the Moomin characters started their adventures in comic strips and later in animation series as well.[32] The Moomins live by their own philosophy, which is based on love, tolerance, and adventure.[33] These values have stuck as an inseparable part of the Moomins, and experiences built around them, such as Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love!, emphasize them as a part of their operations and thematics as well.[34]

While Moomins are not the intended subject of this study and instead take their place as the subject of the experiences used as case studies, it is worth recognizing what may have led to them being strongly represented in experiences built around themed and immersive environments both in Finland and abroad. In 2016, an exhibition called Adventures in Moominland opened in Southbank Centre in London, UK. It was an interactive experiential exhibition with strong themed and immersive elements allowing the audience to explore the Nordic landscape and Moominvalley scenery while learning about them in a way that resembles the premise of the Courage, Freedom, Love! exhibition. [35] In 2019, the Moominvalley theme park opened in Japan as a part of the park facility called Metsä that allows its visitors to experience the Nordic atmosphere with the MoominValley Park highlighting the world of Moomins.[36]

While a part of the Moomins' growing representation in themed and immersive experiences is surely caused by their general popularity and strong visual imagery, their general theme and

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[31] "Muumien maailmanvalloitus alkoi huussin seinältä", Yle, accessed September 12, 2025, https://yle.fi/a/3-7383314.

[32] Savage and Tienari, "*Moomin Management"*, 2.; "Muumimaista elämää: Sitaatteja muumikirjoista eri elämän hetkiin", Moomin.com, accessed December 12, 2025, https://www.moomin.com/fi/blogi/muumikirja-sitaatteja/#5220ed8e.; "The Moomins and the Great Flood – everything you need to know about the first Moomin story", Moomin.com, accessed December 31, 2025, https://www.moomin.com/en/blog/the-moomins-and-the-great-flood/#great-flood-context.

[33] Savage and Tienari, "*Moomin Management*", 2.

[34] "Moominworld", Moominworld, accessed September 11, 2025, https://www.moominworld.fi/moominworld/.; "Courage, Freedom, Love! A Moomin Adventure", Maritime Centre Vellamo, accessed September 11, 2025, https://www.merikeskusvellamo.fi/en/courage-freedom-love-a-moomin-adventure/.

[35] "Immersive 'Adventures in Moominland' now open at the Southbank Centre in London." , Moomin.com, accessed December 12, 2025, https://www.moomin.com/en/blog/adventures-in-moominland/#9dfbad76/.

[36] "History", Moomin.com, accessed September 12, 2025, https://www.moomin.com/en/history/.

origin may also be a root cause. The first Moomin books were written at a time when the author's world was not safe: Helsinki was being bombed and homosexuality was still a crime in Finland.[37] The war painted the queer author's world with shadows and took away the colors.[38] The Moominvalley was created: a safe place where everyone would want to live, and that was based on acceptance, friendliness and adventure.[39] With adventure, the notion of exploration was embedded in the values of the Moomin world from the very beginning.

The rise of themed and immersive Moomin attractions is a part of an emerging trend where experiences are built around existing popular culture, such as books or tv-series.[40] Other such experiences include many different theme lands, such as the Star Wars: Galaxy's Edge in Disneyland, California, or the Wizarding World of Harry Potter at Universal, Orlando. These attractions can remind the guests of why they really cared for the stories, their characters, and themes in the first place.[41] With Moomins, these experiences can bring nostalgia for childhood stories but also create comfort and happiness through the values and reassurance built into the original narrative.

With an experience based on a fairy tale, there is also a different starting point in terms of audience positioning. Compared to a historical re-enactment, or an experience built around a specific country or tradition, an environment based around a fictional story may be easier to approach regardless of one's background. Of course, no visitor ever has the exact same starting point as another, as these experiences are highly individual and allow for their audiences to build their own narrative based on their earlier experiences and knowledge. A Finnish child who has lived their whole life surrounded by Moomins in different forms is naturally going to have a very different experience than a 30-year-old Japanese tourist who first heard of Moomins from their friend on the airplane. Regardless, as is the habit with Moomins, both visitors will be welcomed to their world as equals.

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[37] "Muumilaakson kulissien takana", Yle, accessed September 12, 2025, https://yle.fi/a/74-20179415.; Martti Helminen and Ulpu Marjomaa, "Helsingin suurpommitukset 1944." Historia Helsinki, accessed December 12, 2025, https://historia.hel.fi/fi/kaannekohdat/1900-luku/helsingin-suurpommitukset-1944.; Sateenkaarihistoria Suomessa", Seta, accessed December 30, 2025, https://seta.fi/ihmisoikeudet/sateenkaarihistoria-suomessa/.

[38] Moomin.com, "The Moomins and the Great Flood."

[39] Yle, "Muumilaakson kulissien takana."

[40] Lukas, "*A Reader in Themed and Immersive Spaces*", 4.

[41] Ibid.

1.4.2. Moomin world

Moominworld is a theme park that was opened on the island of Kailo in Naantali, Finland in 1993 by Moominworld Oy, which is a tourist company founded the same year. The park is built around the Moomin characters created by Tove Jansson, who was a Finland-Swedish author and visual artist. Moomins were originally characters in books created by Jansson, but they have since been presented in other forms of media, such as the popular Japanese animation series *Moomin* that was created by Dennis Livson together with Jannson's brother Lars Jansson. [42]

Livson was also the one to come up with the idea for the theme park, which is built around the visual world of the Moomin animation series. The theme park was not only built around the scenery of the Moominvalley, but was intended to carry out its values, also known as Moomin Philosophy, which is reflected in Moominworld and in all of its operations. According to the park's website, the values included in the Moomin philosophy are: "family, non-violence, friendliness, environmental awareness, safety, adventure, and values supporting education."[43]

The park itself is built on an island, offering it some separation from the non-Moomin world surrounding it. The company behind the park, Muumimaailma Oy, operates on the Kailo Island in Naantali's Old Town, which is where the theme park is located, but it also has a café, a shop and a car park in the town center.[44] This study will only be focusing on the theme park on the island, as it is a separate destination that requires visitors to pay an entrance fee to visit Moominworld. The theme park is only open during the summer season.[45] It is mainly an outdoor experience, which also explains the length of the season, as the Finnish summer is short. While there are buildings and other spaces to explore and visit, the audience and in-character staff will spend most of their time outdoors.

Within the park, guests can visit familiar sites from the Moomin stories, such as the Moominhouse. Some of the characters are roaming among the quests and can be found either in their designated areas, such as Snufkin's Camp, or walking among the quests around the

[42] Moominworld, "Moominworld."

[43] Ibid.

[44] Ibid.

[45] Home Page, Moominworld, accessed December 31, 2025, https://www.moominworld.fi/.

central area of the park. Most of the characters are original ones created by Tove Jansson with the exception of the Witch and her granddaughter Alice, who were later added into the storyline through the animation series.

The theme park also has its own theatre where the characters perform plays. This theatre, Theatre Emma, is left outside of this study, as the focus will be on the themed and immersive areas where the audience can freely interact with the characters and their environment rather than being passive audience members to a show.

To avoid confusion, it needs to be noted that when discussing this theme park, it is spelled Moominworld, and when discussing the fantasy world created by Tove Jansson, we are speaking of the Moomin world, or the world of Moomins.

1.4.3. Courage, Freedom, Love!

The Courage, Freedom, Love! exhibition was produced by the National Museum of Finland together with Moomin Characters Oy Ltd. It was first seen at National Museum of Finland in 2020-2021. The second iteration of it opened at the Maritime Museum of Finland on February 14th 2025 and will be on display until March 7th 2027. [46] The exhibition's artistic realization and exhibition architecture is designed by Alexander Reichstein, who is also one of the experts being interviewed for this study. He is responsible for the exhibition's architecture and artistic realization.[47] In addition to the exhibition space itself, the Boat Hall of Maritime Centre Vellamo is also showcasing Tove Jansson and Tuulikki Pietilä's boat, Victoria, which the pair used to travel to their summer home.[48] Due to it being a separate showcase from the exhibition, the boat will not be further studied in this thesis.

The illustrations and quotations displayed in the exhibition are based on original works by Tove Jansson. It is built to enable its guests to pass through familiar sights and explore the scenery known from the Moomin stories. After arriving, they find their way through a dark forest towards the Moominvalley, come to a floating theatre in the ocean, discover the winter scenery known from some of Janssons original stories, and end up in a room that depicts an

[46] Maritime Centre Vellamo, "Courage, Freedom, Love!."

[47] Maritime Centre Vellamo, "Courage, Freedom, Love!."

[48] Ibid.

ocean around a lighthouse island where the visitors can sit on rocks and listen to the storm while watching different characters and vessels pass by.

Among the scenery and theatre set-like rooms, there are display cases filled with drawings, materials and information about Tove Jansson and her work. Much like Moominworld, the Courage, Freedom, Love! exhibition also underlines the values embedded in the original Moomin stories and recognizes them as something that has stayed topical and meaningful to both children and adults to this day. [49]

[49] Ibid.

2. Background and Terminology

The research on themed and immersive spaces is interdisciplinary by nature. Especially when looking at destinations built around a strong existing narrative, interactive elements, and immersion, the design process requires knowledge and collaboration between multiple expertise from storytelling to engineering. Some of the design work can be best understood through experience design, while some aspects of environmental or narrative design are supported by previous studies in game design and immersive theatre. In this chapter, the different terminology used in this study is introduced first, after which the most relevant previous research is presented.

2.1. Terminology

The terminology around themed and immersive experiences is not yet fully established, and many of the words used in this study have been used for different meanings throughout the time. Words such as immersive, interactive, and experience are frequently seen in marketing materials by many different attractions, and the definition of those words may vary. The definitions that are used in this thesis are defined in this chapter.

It needs to be mentioned that the discussion around the terminology of experiences is strongly affected by language and its limitations. Some nuances may be lost in translation, and words may have different meanings in different industries. Due to the interviews for this thesis being conducted in Finnish despite the study itself being written in English, it is crucial to note the difference between English and Finnish when it comes to the word experience. English assigns multiple different meanings to the word *experience*. These include professional experience, someone's experience in a community, as well as the types of experiences discussed in this thesis, which will be further defined in chapter 2.1.1.[50] Meanwhile Finnish has two different words: *elämys* and *kokemus*, the first one being the type of experience the word is used to mean in this thesis, and the latter one describing accumulated experience within a professional field, a community, or a hobby to name a few examples.

[50] Robert J. Rossman, and Mathew D. Duerden, *Designing Experiences* (Columbia University Press, 2019): 9. https://doi.org/10.7312/ross19168.

This difference is, of course, not unique to English and Finnish, and for example Swedish, like Finnish, has two separate words: *upplevelse* and *erfarenhet*. However, for this thesis the issue rises specifically from the difference between Finnish and English. The effect of language differences becomes apparently clear in this thesis, since the interviews are conducted in Finnish and then translated to be used in a thesis written in English. Especially Lohikoski specifically used the word *elämys* when describing their work and what they are offering to their guests. Special care is paid in translating these phrases, but it is possible that some nuance is lost to the lack of the corresponding word in English. Cases where this is apparent will be pointed out in the text.

2.1.1. Designing Experiences

According to experience designer Johanna Koljonen, design is "about identifying limitations, being very clear about goals & aims, and matching needs, goals & resources."[51] All of these need to be taken into account when considering how a space can be designed to support a themed and immersive experience, especially when the goal is to increase audience interaction. These environments, both physical and social, are created to offer the guest the opportunity to experience something other than their everyday life.

When a guest buys an experience, they are expecting something beyond just a service. In terms of economics, experiences were first separated into their own category by Pine and Gilmore, who coined the term experience economy in 1998.[52] Experiences, as defined by them, are "memorable events that engage each individual in an inherently personal way."[53] In their definition, the service becomes an experience once the guests start paying for entry rather than only separate services within the area.[54]

[51] Johanna Koljonen. "Introduction to Narrative Experience Design (Johanna Koljonen at Alibis for Interaction 2015)". Talk, 2015. Posted November 13th, 2015, by Alibis for Interaction. Youtube: 12:00, https://youtu.be/yXjEHDBjrXE?si=c9s2C5OD8o0b28xo.

[52] Pine and Gilmore, "*The Experience Economy*,"

[53] Pine and Gilmore, "Experience Economy: Past, Present and Future," 26.

[54] Joseph B. Pine Ⅱ and James H. Gilmore, "Welcome to the Experience Economy," *Harvard Business Review* 76, no. 4 (1998). https://hbr.org/1998/07/welcome-to-the-experience-economy.

It needs to be said that the definition is not fully established, and other scholars have offered their own take on it. For example, Rossman and Duerden are studying "experiences in the sense of something you personally accomplish, something that you do to affect outcomes, or something that makes you feel a certain way --." They also note that in terms of their study, experiences require the elements of reciprocal interaction between individuals and their surroundings that are sustained by deliberate engagement, and the need for the individual to be aware of something happening around them and contributing to the resulting outcome. [55] The book Elämystuottajan käsikirja, edited by Sanna Tarssanen, underlines that the important differentiation between a service and an experience comes from their positioning towards the customer: a service is about what you can give them, while an experience focuses on how the guest is met.[56]

Due to the individual nature of immersive experiences, the definition by Pine and Gilmore is a fitting one.[57] However, the addition of the individual's active agency by Rossman and Duerden becomes a crucial addition when discussing interactivity.[58] It also places the expectation of the experience being something that is sought out and intentionally participated in. Therefore, in the context of this thesis, an experience is defined as a memorable event that engages each individual in an inherently personal way, and that the individuals themselves are aware of and deliberately taking part in.

Experiences can be rather challenging to research, as their individual nature makes them change based on who is experiencing them. Nevertheless, they can be understood on a broader level. Experience is meant to engage its guests, not just entertain them.[59] Due to this thesis focusing on the elements of immersion and interactivity, it is important to acknowledge the four realms used by Pine and Gilmore in understanding what a well-rounded experience really means.

[55] Rossman and Duerden, "*Designing Experiences*", 9.

[56] Sanna Tarssanen, *Elämystuottajan käsikirja* (Lapin elämysteollisuuden osaamiskeskus, 2009): 9. https://tiimivalmentaja.com/wp-content/uploads/2020/03/elc3a4mystuottajan_kc3a4sikirja.pdf.

[57] Pine and Gilmore, "Experience Economy: Past, Present and Future," 26.

[58] Rossman and Duerden, "*Designing Experiences*", 9.

[59] Pine and Gilmore, "*The Experience Economy*," 30.

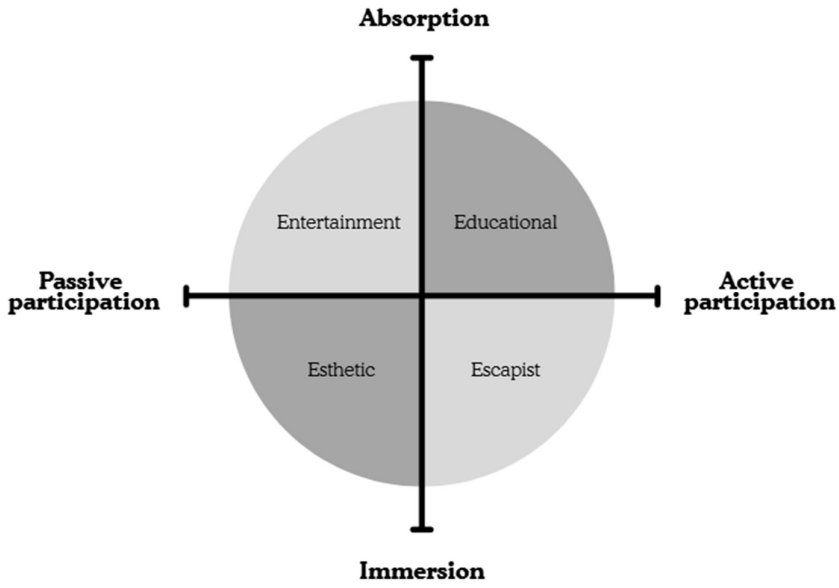


Figure 1. Lukas Jokilehto, The Realms of Experience, 2026, based on a graph in: *Pine and Gilmore,* The Experience Economy – Work Is Theatre & Every Business a Stage*. (Harvard Business School Press, 1999), 30.*

Pine and Gilmore recognize the two most important dimensions on which the guest can be engaged to be: "the level of guest participation" and "the kind of connection or environmental relationship that unites customers with the event or performance." On the graph these are measured as active or passive participation, and whether the guest is immersed in the experience or absorbing it. These two dimensions create the four realms of experience: entertainment, education, escapist and estheticism.[60] The realms are all compatible with one another, and most experiences do not exist in just one at a time. A well-designed experience utilizes all four realms.[61]

2.1.2. Engagement in Themed and Immersive Spaces

Immersion, theming and interaction all have something in common: they make people care about the experience and want to spend time in the space.[62] This can be a powerful tool in any experience, whether it is more focused on entertainment, education, escapism or esthetics, or any combination of the four. A memorable environment increases the chance of a guest returning, and theming can also be used as a way of lessening the negative effects of the less-

[60] Ibid., 30-31.

[61] Ibid., 41.

[62] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 136 & 68-69.

pleasurable parts of the visit, such as queuing.[63] The immersion and willingness to engage are especially powerful when the guest is given the chance to choose to engage rather than expecting them to do so automatically.[64] In this thesis, we aim to explore these three elements: immersion, theming and interaction, as a foundation for discovery and engagement to understand their meaning in creating further opportunities for immersed engagement that the guests would feel compelled to take.

When discussing theming, it should be noted that a theme in terms of themed and immersive spaces is not the same as a theme in literature. A themed space, as described by Scott A. Lukas, means a space that in its foundation has an overarching narrative, symbolic complex, or a story that drives the overall context of their environment. He also points out that all spaces have some sort of a theme or a narrative that provides them with an overarching conceptual purpose. [65] Every space in its own existence is an immersive one, as they surround us in our everyday life. Therefore, it becomes a matter of added value that sets apart what Lukas considers to be themed and immersive spaces. [66]

Added value in a themed and immersive space, it can be offered through different means. Lukas' uses the example of a themed restaurant, which is defined by its function as a restaurant, but offers something more in terms of the experience.[67] This could be a curated menu that is in accordance with the decorations, building a narrative for guests to enjoy with their food. Theming can also help transform a service, such as a restaurant or a mall, into an experience through means of personalization and memorable sensations, both of which are key elements separating services from experiences.[68]

Theming is one of the most popular and powerful forms of immersive world design. It uses an overarching theme or a concept across the space to organize it.[69] It is particularly powerful

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[63] Wanhill, "Creating Themed Entertainment Attractions," 137-138.

[64] Owen Kingston, "Writing for Immersive Theatre - Owen Kingston - Writing for Immersive Experiences", Immersive Experience Network, at 16:22. Recorded in February 2023, uploaded on March 27th, 2023, https://youtu.be/d0ptCizUpiM?si=siucqsguf4jCGW3P.

[65] Lukas, "*A Reader in Themed and Immersive Spaces*", 3.

[66] Ibid., 3-4.

[67] Ibid., 3.

[68] Pine and Gilmore, "*The Experience Economy*," 6.

[69] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 68.

due to its ability to trigger associations.[70] When discussing Moomin-based themed and immersive spaces, it cannot be forgotten that to many they include a nostalgic element, and trigger strong associations through the books and animations many of the guests are familiar with. The effect of previous experiences and associations cannot be fully controlled, though both the guests' and the designers' associations with the theme affect the way the space is built and experienced.[71]

It is also possible for one experience site to have multiple themes within their space. For example, theme parks use different theme lands within the same park to create different environments that the guests can move between. In these cases, special attention should be paid to the transitions between the worlds and the possible overarching theme between them.[72] In both Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love, there are separate areas with sub-themes, such as the winter room in the exhibition, or Whileaway Park in Moominworld. However, all of these are strictly tied to the same Moomin world, making them appear as different parts of the same destination, rather than separate theme lands. Staying within the same fictive world for the entirety of the visit can help the guest to stay immersed.

Compared to theming, immersion as a concept is more difficult to define. Etymology-wise the word comes from the Latin word meaning to plunge or dip. It is still understood as the feeling of being surrounded by something or becoming absorbed by an interest or a situation.[73] In the Realms of Experience model made by Pine and Gilmore, immersion is used as the opposite for absorption – an action requiring the guest to become a part of the experience rather than having it simply brought to their mind.[74] Similarly, anthropologist Scott A. Lukas describes an immersive space as one that is dynamic, interesting, and directly engaging the guest.[75] Rather than just showing or telling guests about the topic at hand, if they get to be involved they will become immersed.[76]

[70] Ibid., 76.

[71] Ibid., 76-77.

[72] Ibid., 79.

[73] Ibid., 4.

[74] Pine and Gilmore, "*The Experience Economy*," 31.

[75] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 155.

[76] Ibid., 103.

Lukas has identified six key elements of immersion: theming, storytelling, design focus, connectors and transitions, the visitor's purpose, and willingness to change.[77] He also points out theming's potential as a tool for creating and maintaining entire worlds.[78] The two experience sites looked at in this thesis also have the benefit of extensive source material, existing tradition, and an already fleshed out story world that the theming is built around. Telling a story in the space helps to remind the guests about why they are in there and to make them care about what is happening around them. The key element of connectors and transitions becomes vital when discussing design elements for encouraging exploration, as they keep the entirety of the experience feeling whole.[79]

According to Lukas, a guest immersed in a space experiences a sense of completeness. The space around them feels like its own complete world telling a story. The guest is a natural part of it and leaves the space transformed.[80] An immersive world, compared to a non-immersive one is detailed and has depth to it. The world is alive and feels as if you could really live in it.[81] Immersive spaces can inflict senses of awe, epic, and imagination. Lukas describes the latter as a possibility of guests drawing connections between the elements in the immersive space and ideas outside of it with them developing vivid associations and an overall sense of imagination.[82] This sense of imagination as described by Lukas is most likely also the basis for the feeling of inspiration that immersive spaces can cause in a guest.

To become immersed, the guest needs to be engaged. This initial engagement can be done through multiple different routes, such as direct interaction with physical elements or in-character staff. This may be a challenge due to capacity being limited, but it allows for a more personalized experience.[83] Only a couple of people can talk to a certain character or use a single device at the same time. This can be combatted through having multiples of the same interaction point, limiting capacity, or using fake interactivity, which means points of interaction that seem interactive but do not change the course of the experience. A guest

[77] Lukas, "*Why Immersion Matters*", 124-126.

[78] Ibid., 124.

[79] Ibid., 126.

[80] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 138.

[81] Ibid., 143.

[82] Ibid., 138.

[83] Younger, *Theme Park Design & the Art of Themed Entertainment.* (Inklingwood Press, 2016): 227.

might be able to flip a switch or push a button that in reality would not change anything but encourages the guest to play anyway.[84]

2.1.3. From a World to a Space

The audience's awareness of the fictional nature of their experience's environment is highlighted in spaces built around existing fictional worlds, such as the Moomin world, with the exception of young children not yet capable of distinguishing between the real and the fictive. As is pointed out by Derek Foster, the fictional foundation of the space's theming leads to the guests always being aware that they are partaking in a real simulation, not simulations of the real. Therefore, the experience does not threaten to undermine reality but is instead a real representation of a fictional world. In the experience, theming becomes a way for the guests to visit this fictional world in the real world through the simulation.[85] By building attractions upon stories the guests are already familiar with, the designers give them the opportunity to enter spaces they have already visited numerous times in their imagination.[86]

Both spaces chosen as case studies for this thesis, Courage, Freedom, Love! and Moominworld, are themed and immersive spaces built around an existing story: that of the Moominvalley and its values. Therefore, the designers have not needed to use much of the space to create and introduce a whole new world but have instead aimed to replicate and present the existing fictional world through a new medium. A well-known, fictional world behind the attractions gives them many needed elements to create immersive experiences, such as background, characters and material elements.[87]

To understand the notion of an immersive world being turned into an immersive space, it is important to specify what we mean when we refer to an immersive world, and how it differs from a space. To better understand this, it is useful to first focus on the definition of a world in this case, as we have already focused on the definition of immersion in chapter 2.1.2. The

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[84] Ibid., 226-227.

[85] Lukas, "*A Reader in Themed and Immersive Spaces*", 174.

[86] Henry Jenkins, "Game Design as Narrative Architecture", (2002). Accessed January 1, 2026: 6. https://paas.org.pl/wp-content/uploads/2012/12/09.-Henry-Jenkins-Game-Design-As-Narrative-Architecture.pdf.

[87] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 156.

anthropologist Scott A. Lukas recognizes that a world can be understood on different scales. It can be used to describe an entire universe, or a planet, but it can also be understood to mean a smaller, more defined system. The word can be used to describe a culture, such as the Mayan culture, which could be understood as a world, or it could be used to refer to a technical world such as World of Warcraft. Most importantly for this study, many themed and immersive entertainment sites can be described as magical worlds, which would be the design definition of the word. [88] The definition used for a world in this thesis is the one by Scott A. Lukas: "A world…is a place inhabited by beings. It is complete, diverse, consistent; it has a background or history, and a culture. It is ever-changing or evolving and is characterized by relationships and forms of interconnection."[89]

Both Moomin spaces investigated in this study are built around the same world. As with any world, real or imagined, a themed and immersive space can never be an exact replica of it. Lukas points out that representing a world is a difficult task, and regardless of the format it will only ever be just that: a representation.[90] Even though Moominworld presents itself as the opportunity to truly visit the Moominvalley, it is still a representation of the larger Moomin world created by Tove Jansson. Simplifications must be made to create it, meaning that the designers must have made choices on what to include and leave out.[91] This process is also actively on-going, as new attractions are being added and old ones modified. The process of simplification and representation of an existing world is also just as true in terms of the exhibition, but due to its format, it is more apparent there, as it is more forthcoming of its role as a representation of the world created by Tove Jansson.

The designer is also not an objective force and, therefore, their own positioning will always leave its mark. Similarly, each guest will bring their own expectations and associations into the experience.[92] This is especially true in spaces built around worlds they are previously familiar with, which is why understanding the source material and the specifics of creating a themed and immersive experience around an existing world needs to be highlighted. Theming and spatial storytelling can also use these pre-existing associations in creating the

[88] Ibid., 4-6.

[89] Ibid., 5.

[90] Ibid., 9.

[91] Ibid.

[92] Ibid., 77.

experience.[93] Jenkins has described video games as a way to give concrete shape to the players' memories and imaginings of a story world, allowing them to wander through and interact with in in an immersive environment.[94] I believe that physical themed and immersive have the same ability to offer a concrete representation of familiar, and new, fictive worlds for us to explore and create memories in.

2.1.4. Exploration

According to Cambridge Dictionary, exploration is "the activity of travelling to and around a place, especially one where you have never been or few people have been before, in order to find out more about it".

In the context of this thesis, exploration is seen as active investigation of one's surroundings through actions such as wandering and interacting with the physical environment, as well as possible other living beings in it, whether it be other guests, characters, or animals, with the goal of discovering more about the surrounding environment. Exploration in this context cannot be linked to a basic need and must instead be driven by the guest's own curiosity and willingness to explore only for the sake of it.

While the definition by Cambridge Dictionary on its own could be seen as satisfactory, this further definition is also a way to emphasize this rather broad action in the context of fantasy-world themed immersive spaces that this thesis focuses on. The addition of engagement through interaction brings the requirement of the explorer being something other than a passive observer and instead expects them to take agency. This links back to the definition of an experience, discussed in chapter 2.1.1., where the guest is expected to be an aware and active participant. It sets the expectation of the explorer wanting to learn something about the space not only due to a basic need, such as hunger, living space, or needing to find the bathroom, but due to another reason such as curiosity or play.

[93] Jenkins, "Game Design" 6-7.; Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 76.

[94] Ibid., 7.

2.1.5. Play and Playfulness

Play is older than humans. It is present in adults, children, and other animals as well, although in different forms. Because of this, it is clear that play has an evolutionary function, though researchers have not fully agreed on what it is. [95] While there is no commonly chosen single definition of human play, it can be described by a few generally accepted characteristics. These characteristics of play are described by psychologist Peter Gray as follows:

(1) self-chosen and self-directed
(2) intrinsically motivated
(3) guided by mental rules
(4) imaginative
(5) conducted in an active, alert, but relatively non-stressed frame of mind.

Gray also notes that play in humans can exist in matters of degree depending on how much the activity contains the characteristics listed above. [96] Play becomes crucial in immersive fantasy spaces due to its ability to help us let go of some of the social norms and instead focus on exploring new opportunities. It can help people engage in their surroundings in new ways and feel safe to adventure.[97]

Even more important than play, it is important to understand the meaning of playfulness to connect these actions to the topic at hand. As described by Stenros, play and playfulness have clear differences between them, and it does not always require playfulness for play to occur. While playing is something social, playfulness is rather something happening in the mind of an individual, much like the feeling of immersion.[98] Due to this, the expectation of rules is also not shared between play and playfulness, as the latter does not need the participation of others to occur. As defined by Stenros, a playful mindset means "doing something for the

[95] Jaakko Stenros, "Playfulness - Larp talk by Jaakko Stenros". Talk, 2016. Posted July 7th, 2016, by Larpwriter Summer School. Youtube: 00:18, https://youtu.be/ImCEkjXP6-U?si=vzt7IH34NKVAD4yK.

[96] Peter Gray, "Definitions of Play", *Scholarpedia*. 8. 30578. 10.4249/scholarpedia.30578.

[97] Jaakko Stenros, "Playfulness, Play, and Games: A Constructionist Ludology Approach" (PhD diss., Tampere University, 2015), 215, *Tampere University Press*, https://urn.fi/URN:ISBN:978-951-44-9788-9.

[98] Stenros, "Playfulness", at 15:00.

sake of doing it."[99] This differentiation is not mentioned by Gray, who does not differentiate between play and playful activity in his list, but it is inherently important in the context of this study. For a playful mindset to occur, the person experiencing it needs to feel safe. Notably, Stenros points out that this feeling of safety and actually being safe are not always the same thing.[100]

The exploration of a themed and immersive environment built around a known story world often takes place in a playful mindset and can also include elements of play, as described by Stenros, due to the social nature of some of the encounters. As we defined the exploration to be an activity done for the sake of itself rather than a function, it comes close to what Stenros describes play, if not exactly that. Especially in the context of themed and immersive experiences representing an existing story world, the actions taken by guests can be seen as a playful activity. Due to the foundation of the world they are visiting being fictional, the guests are always aware of the experience being a simulation. However, instead of allowing the knowledge of the world's fictive nature take over, they can still choose to believe.[101] Exploring a fictional world and connecting with its characters may not result in any advances in the real world around it, yet the guests choose to do so anyway. Therefore, making it easier for guests to get into a playful mindset may encourage them to explore the world further and engage in their surroundings.

People can easily get lost, uncomfortable, and confused and if that happens, they stop being brave, curious, and willing to engage. Experience design's aim is to allow guests to be active participants without feeling any of the forementioned negative emotions.[102] This can be especially challenging with grown-up guests. Adult play is still a taboo in many cultures.[103] Trying out new behaviors, especially those outside of the expected norm such as climbing a rope in a museum, can be daunting. This confusion or uncertainty can hinder exploration,

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[99] Ibid., at 08:50.

[100] Stenros, "Playfulness, Play, and Games", 133.

[101] Lukas, "A Reader in Themed and Immersive Spaces", 174.

[102] Johanna Koljonen, "Introducing Alibis for Interaction: Experience Design Basics". Talk, 2015. Posted March 27th, 2014, by Alibis for Interaction. Youtube: 19:55, *https://youtu.be/xe9OWbxd0qg?si=0N3vmTbwiUfDDX5p.;* Koljonen, "Introduction to Narrative Experience Design," at 01:35

[103] Stenros, "Playfulness", at 14:35.

especially if it requires social interaction. One way for designers to address this is to offer their guests clear alibis for interaction.

An alibi for interaction, as described by Johanna Koljonen is "a social rule, physical object or situation that allows someone to try a new behavior or experience or initiate an interaction."[104] Additionally, Stenros points out that the state of play can also work as an alibi.[105] This further emphasizes the need to understand play as a tool for encouraging experimentation and engagement. As an example, an alibi can be offered through a mask or darkness providing anonymity. This allows a guest to feel more comfortable in trying out a new behavior. An alibi can also be a task.[106] If you have been specifically instructed to walk backwards, it becomes easier than just deciding to do so, since you are just following instructions. In a fantasy setting you have perhaps been told to approach characters and go tell them something, giving you an alibi for the interaction. It is the experience designer's responsibility to provide the needed alibi for interaction within the experience.[107] It eases the guests' anxiety, provides them with direction, and makes them more comfortable in the environment, which can help them be more open to exploring and interacting to create more positive associations and memories.

Alibis for interaction can also help the guest to step into a magic circle. A magic circle is a chosen place and time where an experience is separated from the rest of the world. Inside the limits of the circle, the social rules and consequences to certain actions are different from those of the outside world.[108] For example, when a character gets killed in a theatrical act or a live-action role play, which take place inside a magic circle separating it from the real world, the person playing that character is still alive outside of the magic circle and their killer will not be charged in the real world. A magic circle can help break down social norms and allow people to act in a way they normally would not feel comfortable with. Koljonen uses carnivals as an example of a social space where it is okay for everyone to act weird, as it is a specific time and place – a magic circle.[109] This concept is helpful in experience design, when the goal

[104] Koljonen, "Introduction to Narrative Experience Design," at 16:05.

[105] Stenros, "Playfulness", at 30:20.

[106] Koljonen, "Introducing Alibis for Interaction," at 03:55.

[107] Ibid., at 13:20.

[108] Ibid., at 05:40.

[109] Ibid., at 07:20.

is to encourage guests to behave in a way that differs from the usual norms. Perhaps they need to talk to a character they perceive as a stranger or go through the items in a character's closet to find out more details about them. Establishing a magic circle, making the guests feel like it is okay to do these things in this space at this time, offering them an alibi for interaction, and ensuring they know where and when the limits of the experience go can help them be more comfortable, and therefore more active participants.

2.2. Previous Research

Themed and immersive experiences are built as a collaboration between many fields. Therefore, they are also best understood through interdisciplinary research. Valuable concepts can be found from performance studies, game studies, and anthropology among others. These existing concepts are threaded together to create a net that functions as the foundation for the new information discovered in this study to create a deeper understanding of guest engagement within themed and immersive experiences.

Experiences as an economic asset have been studied by Pine and Gilmore, who also coined the term experience economy in their book The Experience Economy – Works Is Theatre & Every Business a Stage in 1999. Their concept of the four realms of experience: entertainment, educational, esthetic, and escapist, functions as a guideline for well-rounded experiences and helps understanding the effects of active participation and immersion in an experience.[110] However, they focus on experiences on a very broad scale and discuss them mostly from an economic perspective. For the design perspective, J. Robert Rossman and Mathew D. Duerden's book Designing Experiences offers a broad packet of information about designing experiences, spaces, and the guests' journey. Their analysis of the phases of an experience: anticipation, participation, and reflection is especially useful when discussing expectation management.[111] Nevertheless, much like Pine and Gilmore's, their work also focuses on experiences on a quite general level.

Themed and immersive spaces as a concept have been defined and studied by the anthropologist Scott A. Lukas, mainly whose definitions of these spaces will be used in the

[110] Pine and Gilmore, "The Experience Economy," 30-38.

[111] Rossman and Duerden, "Designing Experiences", 9.

context of this study. The Immersive Worlds Handbook: Designing Theme Parks and Consumer Spaces written by him serves as a foundational text in understanding immersive design in physical spaces. Further discussions on themed and immersive spaces specifically can be found in the text collection called A Reader in Themed and Immersive Spaces, edited by Lukas, which has contributions from researchers, critics, and design professionals around the world.[112] Lukas' key elements of immersion also become a key element in understanding experience design within themed and immersive spaces.[113]

Additionally, Josephine Machon has written about immersion and interaction in her book Immersive Theatres: Intimacy and Immediacy in Contemporary Performance. Similarly to Lukas, she has identified key pillars of what makes something an immersive experience. However, as her work focuses on experiences intended as artistic practice, and heavily focuses on performance arts specifically, it makes more sense to follow the definitions by Lukas in this thesis. Still, Machon's work remains relevant in the broader discussion around the elements of immersion and performance.[114]

While the texts by Lukas serve well in defining and analyzing themed and immersive spaces, they are broad. Lukas' handbook can serve as a textbook for designing immersive spaces, but it also means that each subject is covered rather briefly. Similarly, the reader offers valuable insights but does not efficiently draw them together. This thesis aims to combine the expertise offered in these contributions and combine them with further information collected from the case studies to gain an understanding of how themed and immersive experiences can be designed in a way that offers the most opportunities for further exploration.

Due to this idea of exploration without a specific function, such as fulfilling a need, it becomes crucial to understand the notions of play. The game scholar Jaakko Stenros' work in defining play and playful behavior, as well as Johanna Koljonen's work with alibis for interaction in terms of experience design, as discussed in chapter 2.1.5., become especially important in understanding guests' actions and the tools that can be used for encouraging wanted behaviors. Game studies also offer important insights into the work of actors in an

[112] Lukas, "A Reader in Themed and Immersive Spaces", back cover.

[113] Lukas, "Why Immersion Matters".

[114] Machon, "Immersive Theatres".

immersive and interactive environment, as well as spatial storytelling. Especially the article Game Desing as Narrative Architecture by Henry Jenkins acts as a viable source for information on narrative structures and spatial storytelling.[115] While Jenkins discusses the matters in the context of games, many of the same ideas are also useful in understanding experience design within themed and immersive experiences.

In understanding the use of human agents, or in the case of Moominworld the in-character staff, another text by Jaakko Stenros rises as an important study into the experience and roles of interactive actors, or ractors, in live action roleplay, often also called LARP. This study can also be used to understand the role of the in-character staff in themed environments where the guests are active participants but not taking part in a pre-planned game like they would in a live-action roleplay. Stenros has identified six functions that the ractors fulfill in a LARP. These are: facilitating, content creation, character portrayal, entertainment, playing and safeguarding.[116] While originally recognized by Lukas in a study looking at ractors as a tool for runtime gamemastering, these will also be useful in understanding the roles of in-character staff in themed environments.

In LARP, runtime gamemastering refers to the action of controlling the players while the game is already on-going.[117] Although a pre-planned game requires different types of control compared to a theme park, there are still a lot of similarities in the need to manage expectations, safety and enjoyment of the guests or players in a way that does not break immersion. While this can be done through technology or other means, Stenros specifically points out that human agents can be often be an easier, faster and more robust solution.[118] These human agents are able to support the game masters in tracking the players actions, events happening near them, their input, and in general the overall picture of the game unfolding around them. They can also function as an actuating system allowing the game masters to influence player activity through them. [119] In a theme park, while there is not a similar need to control the players to forward a specific storyline, the in-character staff can be

[115] Jenkins, ”Game Design”.

[116] Stenros, “Between Game Facilitation and Performance,” 76.

[117] Ibid., 78.

[118] Ibid.

[119] Ibid.

used to guide guests towards opportunities of immersion and interaction to create additional value for them.

Another environment where tools for immersion and the interaction between actors and audience have been discussed is immersive theatre. Rose Biggin discusses the audience experience in immersive theatre in her book Immersive Theatre and Audience Experience – Space, Game and story in the Work of Punchdrunk. She refers to the famous immersive theatre group Punchdrunk, that has often also been cited as pioneers of the genre.[120] She discusses possible barriers to immersion and audiences' behavior in an immersive experience, which becomes highly relevant in the discussion of elements that can be used to encourage further engagement through adding cues or removing obstacles.[121]

One of the structures Biggin uses to understand interactivity within immersive experiences is a four-mode model by Salen and Zimmerman to describe different categories of narrative interaction. These categories have previously been discussed in Zimmerman's work and first appeared in print in his essay called Against Hypertext.[122] For this thesis, it becomes especially important through the further research by Biggin, who uses it to discuss immersive theatre through an analysis of The Drowned Man by Punchdrunk.

In Salen and Zimmerman's model, the four modes of interaction are:

1. Cognitive interactivity
2. Functional interactivity
3. Explicit interactivity
4. Beyond-the-object interactivity[123]

In her work, Biggin focuses on the three first ones, which will also be the most relevant for this thesis, as it mainly focuses on the interactivity taking place within the experience space.

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[120] Biggin, "Immersive Theatre", 2.

[121] Biggin, "Immersive Theatre."

[122] Zimmerman, Eric, "Narrative, Interactivity, Play, and Games: Four naughty concepts in need of discipline", accessed January 1, 2026, https://ericzimmerman.com/assets/pdfs/Four_Concepts.pdf.; Eric Zimmerman, "Against Hypertext." *American Letters & Commentary*, vol. 12 (2000): 77-82, accessed January 1, 2026, https://ericzimmerman.com/assets/pdfs/Against_Hypertext.pdf.

[123] Biggin, "Immersive Theatre", 74.; Zimmerman, "Narrative, Interactivity, Play, and Games."

As is in Biggin's work, it is important here as well to remember that interaction does not yet guarantee immersion. Instead, as Biggin said: "Certain modes or moments of interactivity may facilitate and/or allow for it more than others, being a way to lower barriers to immersive experience and draw audience member into the work."[124] While her work focuses on these four modes in terms of immersive theatre, her is relevant when looking at themed and immersive environments, especially those with actors within them. Even without the presence of actors, her analysis of barriers to immersion, together with the definition of play requiring a feeling of safety, becomes a key pillar in understanding the kind of environment that needs to be created for engagement to be desirable.

This thesis aims to understand the creation of immersion and the elements used to encourage further engagement and exploration without breaking it. It does need to be noted that there are multiple scholars discussing whether immersion is something that should be sought after and if so, to what level it should, or is even possible to, be achieved. While not the focus of this study, being aware of these criticisms of the use of immersion, theming, and interactive elements in different spaces is important. Especially when discussing using immersive and interactive elements in museum settings, the risks of reconstruction and subjectivity need to be brought up. Much like a director's vision shapes how a character's story is shown in a film, the designer's vision of a world shapes the way it is reconstructed.

This was discussed by, for example, Christina Kerz, who has studied the living history museum Colonial Williamsburg. She states that American history has been shaped in and through the living museum, and that the accuracy of its efforts to preserve and recreate the symbols and memorials of a specific period in history had been questioned.[125] There is a conflict between the need of guests being safe and comfortable and the goal of getting them engaged in an experience depicting a period with uncomfortable topics such as slavery. Colonial Williamsburg is also not the only immersive experience battling with this dilemma.[126] Sanitizing complications of the real world in themed and immersive representations is one of the major critiques applied to themed and immersive spaces.[127]

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[124] Biggin, "Immersive Theatre", 74 & 80.

[125] Lukas, "*A Reader in Themed and Immersive Spaces*", 196.

[126] Ibid., 198.

[127] Ibid., 10.

Themed and immersive spaces have also been criticized for utilizing stereotypes and simplifications in their design, badly copying other places and people, lack of authenticity, and consumerism. Lukas also lists the tendency to gear these spaces towards escapism, reflection of inherently negative values such as consumerism and competition, and the use of unrelated or disconnected symbols, things or qualities in what is made to appear as a unified whole. Lastly, he mentions the concern of themed and immersive spaces potentially focusing their guests' attention on certain contexts and behaviors that can negatively affect individuals or the society as a whole.[128]

While their fictional foundation lessens the worry for stereotypes and wrongful representations, other concerns, such as the critiques of consumerism and escapism, can still be present in themed and immersive experiences built around story worlds. Every experience designer should be aware of the risks connected to designing spaces that have the potential to tell a powerful story and leave a lasting memory. Especially if an experience is built around an existing world within the real world, such as another country or a culture, the possible conflicts between the needs of immersion and encouraging exploration, and the existing narrative and associations need to be paid special attention to.

[128] Ibid.

3. Exploring Opportunities for Engagement

Most guests desire to experience a space with no bounds, where they can be free to explore. They are looking for adventure, freedom and discoveries, and want to feel like they are a part of something bigger.[129] All of this can be offered through a well-designed themed and immersive experience whether it is taking place in a museum, theme park, or a world fair. In this study, the Moominworld theme park and the Courage, Freedom, Love! exhibition are studied to find out how guests can be encouraged to adventure further and explore the space to discover more than they may have done without prompting.

The two case studies are very different. One is a mainly outdoor theme park and the other an indoor exhibition space. The experts interviewed are also working in different roles, one as a producer and the other as an exhibition architect. It will be interesting to see the differences and similarities between the two experiences and how they are designed. To understand the positioning of the interviewees, it is good to understand their roles in their respective projects.

Ida-Maria Lohikoski is a producer at Moominworld. She works in the Experience team and Customer Experience team. For an accurate translation, it needs to be noted that the name Experience team uses the Finnish word *elämys*, so it focuses on experiences as they are understood in this thesis, while the latter, Customer Experience team, uses the word *kokemus*, separating it from the first one. Lohikoski also has experience working as a character in Moominworld herself. Now she trains the new in-character staff taking on the job each year.[130]

Alexander Reichstein is an artist and an illustrator working in Helsinki, Finland. His projects have been exhibited in multiple countries, and he has been rewarded for his work in literature. His exhibitions often include interactive elements allowing guests to engage in the art in different ways.[131] He is the exhibition architect for the Courage, Freedom, Love! exhibition.

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[129] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 185.

[130] *Ida-Maria Lohikoski, interview by Lukas Jokilehto, September 25, 2025.*

[131] Alexander Reichstein, "about me", accessed January 1, 2026, https://www.reichstein.name/about_me.html.

According to Reichstein, he was behind the whole concept of the exhibition including the visuals and the room layout. Since there was no script, he created the exhibition's narrative based on the instructions to bring out the values of the Moomin world.[132]

Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love! are both examples of a themed and immersive experience built into a specific physical space. The audience pays for the experience of spending time in the space where they can explore the sites of a pop-culture-based fairytale world that most of them are familiar with from either the books by Tove Jansson, the animation series, or some other media. Supporting the audience's agency and providing opportunities for discovery can initiate positive emotions that not only encourage them to explore further but can then be associated with the topic of the experience, and the visit as a whole. Therefore, these positive associations can not only help with learning, inspiration, and personal connections, but also create the desire to seek out more experiences in similar spaces.

Themed and immersive environments are known to be a useful tool in introducing new topics and helping guests feel connected to them through engagement and previous associations.[133] They can therefore be used as an incentive for guests to visit new types of attractions and spaces, such as museums, learning centers, or outdoor exhibitions. The tools used for immersion, interaction, and themed design are flexible, and can be used in different kinds of spaces.

3.1. The Guest

"The guest is where any themed or immersive space begins and ends, plain and simple."[134] This quote by Scott A. Lukas is easy to agree with, especially considering the individual nature of immersion and the phases of an experience by Rossman and Duerden. "The visitor's purpose" is one of the key elements in creating immersive spaces, and the guests' needs must be the focus of a successful design.[135] An experience is reliant on there being someone to

[132] Alexander Reichstein, interview by Lukas Jokilehto, September 25, 2025.

[133] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 76-77 & 155.

[134] Ibid., 150.

[135] Lukas, "*Why Immersion Matters*", 126.

experience it, and immersion in a space can only occur through a guest. Everything designers do in a space, whether themed and immersive or not, is about the guest.[136]

The guests' importance does not solely come from the capitalistic side of the experience economy. While they do pay money to enter the spaces sold as experiences and spend their time and energy to visit these attractions, there are other factors that make the guest matter in the context of designing themed and immersive spaces. These spaces are arenas for self-development, inspiration, and new connections to the world around them.[137] In Lukas' words: "These are spaces of possibility, transformation, and excitement. Creating a space that guests truly love is a human act—one that can change the lives of guests [and workers] in dramatic ways."[138] Guests come into each experience with pre-existing associations and knowledge of the topic.[139] This changes not only the way they interact with the space, but what they expect from it to begin with. The effect of these expectations is further discussed in chapter 3.6.

In immersive productions that emphasize audience exploration it is common for the narratives to be created on an individual level through each guest's route, as they piece together separate rooms and scenes into a wider world.[140] This intellectual and emotional engagement is typical for cognitive interactivity, which is the first of the four categories recognized by Salen and Zimmerman.[141] Biggin discusses this imaginative participation as one of the facilitators of immersion in Punchdrunk's The Drowned Man, where it becomes a way for an audience member to create their own narrative through exploration and discovery with much of it linking to the pathfinding and navigation of the physical space. In The Drowned Man, it was also likely a guest would become disoriented and discover scenes without knowing the full context for them.[142] This, in turn, means that during the performance, it is likely that there will be multiple guests following a scene with differing knowledge of its positioning within the story.

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[136] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook",* 150.

[137] Ibid., 151.

[138] Ibid.

[139] Ibid., 77.

[140] Biggin, "*Immersive Theatre*", 80.

[141] Ibid.; Salen and Zimmerman, *Rules of Play: Game Design Fundamentals*. (MIT Press, 2004): 59.

[142] Biggin, "*Immersive Theatre*", 81.

Similarly, as both Moominworld with its characters and Courage, Freedom, Love! with its animations live their own lives, the guests may walk into an on-going scene without fully knowing what is happening. This offers limitless possibilities in terms of the individual experiences of the guest and the narratives they build. Still, there are risks of barriers to immersion within this approach of inviting guests to freely explore. In The Drowned Man's case, guests were given a synopsis of the story at the start of their experience, suggesting that some previous knowledge was required for full engagement. The anxiety over whether or not they are experiencing the plot in the best or correct way may end up acting as a barrier to immersion and stopping the guest from enjoying the show to its fullest.[143]

The anxiety induced by mixed signals is a risk worth noting. However, such mixing signals were not strongly present in Moominworld nor Courage, Freedom, Love!. Both of them are physically built as open areas and though the exhibition is limited to its walls, the guests can still quite easily see its contents and return to examine things they have previously seen with ease without the risk of becoming disoriented. Moominworld again, while larger as an area, is built as an open world and the guests are provided with a map to help them find what they are looking for. The only noticeable example of a possible risk in interrupting the guests' free exploration were the occasional announcements made in Moominworld about scheduled events that were about to begin. The program including these events was available to guests, but during the observation there were a couple of instances of an announcement being made about an event starting on the other side of the park causing temporary rush. Not every guest had a map and making it to another place for a scheduled event, especially with small children, can be challenging and cause the feeling of missing out. That being said, these announcements were quite rare, and there was also programming that was never announced, nor officially scheduled. These hidden events will be discussed in more detail in chapter 3.2.1.

Both Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love! offer opportunities for cognitive interaction – the act of piecing together a story through clues, exploration and engagement. In both venues there are places where a guest can discover details of a character through finding some of their belongings, such as Moominmamma's handbag in the exhibition and the drawers and wardrobes available for exploration in the Moominhouse in the theme park. To some, these offer the chance to make completely new interpretations of the characters and

[143] Ibid.

their lives, and some may find familiar items that enforce their existing idea of the story world. Finding a familiar item also caused some positive interactions, as guests were happy to recognize a detail and share their knowledge with others.

In terms of immersion, it is important to consider the role a guest is taking on when visiting a themed and immersive experience site, especially one built around an existing world. Guests at the Harry Potter World may dress as witches and wizards to slip into characters within the wizarding world, creating a difference between their normal self and the role they fulfill in the experience. This way other guests become a bigger part of the worldbuilding for others, and it can work as an alibi for interaction within the experience. In both Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love!, the visitor enters the world of Moomins as themselves. While they can, of course, choose to think of themselves as someone living in the Moominvalley, the experiences themselves do not offer an opportunity to dress up, with the exception of the theatre stage in the exhibition space. Especially Moominworld makes a distinction between their guests and the Moominvalley inhabitants. This is also seen in some of their signage indicating a staff area, which are marked as "for Moominvalley residents only". Then again, Reichstein highlights that Courage, Freedom, Love!' offers its guests the chance to live like Moomins and exist in their world almost as one of its characters.[144] However, this strong feeling of immersion and connection is up to each guest and cannot easily be observed.

Separation between the guests and the world can function as a barrier to immersion, as the awareness of your everyday self being on the line may cause uncertainty and hesitance. During both observation periods in Courage, Freedom, Love!, there were moments when guests were hesitant to try out some of the more unusual behaviors in the context of a museum. During the first period where I focused on my own experience, this hesitance was highlighted in spaces where there was museum staff present at the same time. While it cannot be said for certain, it also seemed to be the case with some other visitors that were observed during the second phase. One explanation is the internalized behavior patterns that are taught to many of the guests, me included, from a young age. Especially if there is uncertainty about whether an action is permitted, wanting to avoid embarrassment of being told to stop may act as a strong barrier to immersion and discourage guests from exploring the opportunities offered. This hesitance may have also been partly due to the museum staff belonging to the

[144] Reichstein, interview.

context of the museum, not the context of Moomin world. The Courage, Freedom, Love! exhibition is clearly built for play. Still, guests might be uncertain about whether to follow the rules of Moominworld and climb up ropes where possible, or the known social rules of a museum and not touch anything, especially if not told otherwise.

Anxiety over rules can act as a barrier to immersion. Guests may feel lost and stay aware of being present in an experience rather than being able to become immersed in it.[145] The issues of functional interactivity, another category recognized by Salen and Zimmerman, become key in laying the foundation for a successful immersive experience.[146] The guests will not be able to get properly immersed in their surroundings if they are uncomfortable, involuntarily lost, or anxious about not finding or being able to access what they are looking for.[147] Barriers to immersion can be social, mental, or physical, such as the lack of a ramp for a wheelchair user, or too many people in the same space preventing a guest from seeing around them. Some of these can be tackled by offering alibis for interaction, but some require more physical solutions or controlling the guest flow. The forementioned map of Moominworld (see Figure 7) and the exhibition's easy layout (see Figure 9) serve as examples of solutions to support functional interactivity within a themed and immersive experience, as they keep the guests from becoming lost or confused about their environment.

Immersion can also be broken by encounters with the space itself. A crucial element in designing immersive experiences is to ensure that the environment is not scary or otherwise anxiety-inducing on its own. This is of course different when it comes to horror attractions or dark theming, so perhaps it would be best to speak of non-expected or genre-non-typical scares and atmospheres. In Moominworld, things should not be scary, but exciting or suspenseful, while Courage, Freedom, Love!'s most intensive elements can be a little scary for the youngest guests.[148] In Moominworld, there may be moments where one gets to overcome oneself and get the feeling of achievement after doing something that they were not certain of, but the park aims to specifically evoke the feelings of joy, happiness, and safety.[149]

[145] Biggin, "*Immersive Theatre*", 86-87.

[146] Ibid., 85.; Salen and Zimmerman, "*Rules of Play*", 59.

[147] Biggin, "*Immersive Theatre*", 86-87.

[148] Lohikoski, interview.; Reichstein, interview.

[149] Lohikoski, interview.

A necessary distinction here is that Lohikoski uses the Finnish word *jännittävä* to describe an experience that the park could have. In the paragraph above, this was translated to exciting or suspenseful, but those do not quite grasp the feeling behind the word. A proper translation is difficult to find from English, but there are examples, such as the Swedish word *spännande* that much like *jännittävä* describes a situation that generates suspense in the person experiencing it, but not in a way that would make them really scared. Instead, it makes the person excited or slightly nervous. Especially in this context it should be understood as a positive experience with something that the person wants to do despite the suspense or mild scariness of it.

An example of such an attraction in Moominworld could be the Groke's cave. The character is very popular and has been highly requested figure in Moominworld.[150] However, in the Moomin stories she is seen as a scary figure that is associated with loneliness and coldness. Almost all residents of the Moominvalley fear her, even if the character in the end is portrayed as not evil, but lonely or misunderstood.[151] In 2025 the Groke made her return to Moominworld after her previous removal due to her house's poor condition at the time.[152] The Groke is not portrayed by an actor but is instead an animatronic character in a small cave alongside Invisible Ninni's Trail. It is possible to bypass the cave, but many want to visit, which even led to some unexpected queues forming during the summer.[153] Despite the popularity, during the observation period many children hesitated at the entrance of the cave and waited for their parents' encouragement to enter. Afterwards, the children's relief and joy of having overcome themselves was clear in most cases.

Being able to make the choice between entering or not allows the guests to make their own decisions and create a narrative of their own choosing by skipping the more suspenseful attractions. This is also the case with Hattifattener's cave that similarly to the Groke's cave has a darker atmosphere. The possibility of skipping these attractions creates a feeling of certainty, where it is safe to explore and travel across the Moominvalley knowing that you

[150] Ibid.

[151] "The Groke, a Much-misunderstood Creature", Moomin.com, accessed December 30, 2025, https://www.moomin.com/en/blog/groke/#4d52b2f2.

[152] Lohikoski, interview.; "Ikimuistoinen päivä Muumimaailmassa Naantalissa", Moomin.com, accessed December 30, 2025, https://www.moomin.com/fi/blogi/muumimaailma-naantali/#4d52b2f2.

[153] Lohikoski, interview.

will not accidentally end up in a space that is scary for you or your companions. Sound design is also used in controlling the amount of suspense in these attractions, keeping them in line with the goal of not scary, but exciting.[154]

The general atmosphere of safety and choice helps in ensuring the guests that it is safe to peak into caverns and houses without the fear of being jump-scared or ending up somewhere with completely different social rules. The consistency not only helps in keeping up the immersion but encourages movement in the park. In the case of Moominworld, it also allows the characters to move freely around the park without ever seeming out of place, even if they visit each other's areas. The free movement of guests and characters can be supported by the design of the transitional spaces, which are one of the key elements of immersive spaces recognized by Scott A. Lukas.[155]

As stated before, immersion, experience, and playfulness are all things happening in one's mind. It cannot be forced, and similarly, the decision to seek more can never be guaranteed as the guests write their own stories in the sets provided. No matter how many brilliant cues are laid out, not everyone is going to follow them despite their age. Perhaps they are tired, busy looking after their children, or just not interested in finding out more, even if the chance to explore the story further is perfectly presented.

The level of immersion can vary from high to relatively low. In the latter case, the guest may not feel wrapped up in the experience, and immersion most likely does not occur.[156] However, a space designed to offer an immersive experience can still be enjoyed in other ways, such as a purely visual experience. How much the guest does get immersed is not fully up to the designer, as there is always a subjective factor at play.[157] No two guests can ever have the same experience, whether it is immersive or not.[158] This individual nature of all experiences combined to the subjectivity of immersion makes immersive experiences a challenging design endeavor.

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[154] Ibid.

[155] Lukas, "Why Immersion Matters", 126.

[156] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 136-137.

[157] Ibid., 158.

[158] Pine and Gilmore, "*The Experience Economy*," 12.

3.2. Social Dynamics

In all the spaces within these case studies, it is rare to be alone in the space. There was one period where I was left alone in Courage, Freedom, Love! for some time, but other than that all spaces always had multiple people present. Even if there is only a singular guest in the space at a time, an experience always has a social aspect to it regardless.[159] Both Courage, Freedom, Love! attract a lot of children and families. They also receive adult guests with no children with them. In Moominworld, there is a rising trend of groups of adults visiting the park together.[160] Therefore, it is important to consider how these spaces are read by both adults and children.

Much of Courage, Freedom, Love!'s exhibition space is built as a playable ground. Reichstein points out that while an adult accompanying children may not as often engage in active play, they may remain immersed in the world surrounding them and interact with it through their kids. Through their play in the world of Moomins, the children become characters themselves and function as an extension of the world, offering a new point of interaction to the adult guests with them.[161] Not only can they bring in the adult to play with them, take part as an audience, or photograph them playing, but they can show details and opportunities through play and discovery.

This is not to say that an adult would always refrain from playing or would not become a part of the world. It is this exact dive into the world of Moomins and getting a chance to live like them that Reichstein describes as the experience the exhibition has to offer. He describes it as something that cannot be read or seen online and is instead offered through the physical space and experience within it. According to him, being surrounded by the world of Moomins from all sides creates the most powerful aspect of engagement and acts as the main source of interaction in the exhibition.[162] This description plays with the definitions of immersion and interactivity, as they are understood in this thesis. It is clear that being immersed in the world can push the guests to try out new things and seek engagement within the space. A guest can

[159] Koljonen, "Introduction to Narrative Experience Design," at 07:15.

[160] Lohikoski, interview.

[161] Reichstein, interview.

[162] Ibid.

be guided to explore by their immersion, as they treat their surroundings as what they represent. Reichstein uses an example of young guests climbing onto the light house island to lay down, as they would do on a real beach. In this manner, immersion creates a space that encourages the guests to act as they would near an ocean, not in a museum exhibition. However, if the guest cannot get fully immersed, or the space does not offer a clear action, this type of interaction with the space can be daunting for some guests.

If the social rules of a space are unclear, the guest is left uncertain of which set to follow to avoid embarrassment that would come from a staff member needing to ask them to stop a behavior they had assumed to be acceptable. Especially for adults, there were at times uncertainties about whether or not they were allowed to climb the rope, take the stage, or cross the bridge, or if those things were only meant and built for children. These were intensified when the structure did not feel sturdy enough to comfortably carry an adult's weight. This links back to the notion by Stenros of something being safe and feeling safe not being the same thing.[163] If it was clear that the construction was safe and intended for all guests despite their age or size, interaction was more free and spontaneous. For example, multiple adults were seen hopping from one ice block to another. These were simply painted on the floor in one of the rooms. There was space to go around them, but many chose to play instead.

On the contrary, the bridge in the first room caused uncertainty in multiple adults. When entering the space through the dark forest, the pathway painted on the floor leads the guest to the Moominvalley, and to a small bridge going over painted water. Many adults stopped by the bridge and wondered, some aloud, whether the bridge would carry their weight. Most ended up testing, with clear hesitance, and after feeling the bridge to be sturdy would feel more comfortable crossing it again. Still, this early uncertainty broke some of the illusion and sparked the thought: Is this space built for me, an adult?

[163] Stenros, "Playfulness, Play, and Games", 133.



Figure 2. Alexander Reichstein, The Bridge in Courage, Freedom, Love!.

As was pointed out by Stenros, adult play is still somewhat of a taboo.[164] This can lead into a situation where adult guests are more careful about engaging in playful behavior within an experience. The hesitance rising from existing social norms can be increased by some of the exhibition's interactive elements clearly being designed for children, which is indicated by size and positioning. Due to this, it can be more natural for younger guests to begin play and enter a magic circle within the exhibition. For an adult, the task may be more difficult, especially if there are no sufficient alibis for interaction.

Inside a magic circle the consequences for one's actions are different, but if the guest is not certain whether or not they can let go of the social norms of the physical space they are in and instead follow the rules of the story world, they may not be certain which set of consequences to expect. The uncertainty about rules and boundaries can risk breaking immersion, as the guest is trying to balance between the opportunities of the story world and the rules and expectations of the everyday world they are located within. In some cases, this uncertainty seemed to be highlighted in Courage, Freedom, Love! by the presence of museum staff. The presence of an exhibition attendant seemed to especially alter the behavior of adult guests. Hesitance to interact with objects, especially those requiring physical activity, was more noticeable in the rooms where the exhibition attendant had a line of sight, and people were glancing to their direction before performing an action. This behavior did not seem as present during a period when the exhibition attendant was not present. Even if at the beginning of one's visit the rules are not clear, the people who spent more time in the exhibition space

[164] Ibid., at 14:35.

tended to relax and start interacting more with the objects and explore the space further. Part of this was possibly caused by them observing other people being able to act in certain ways without receiving any negative feedback from the staff, nor the people around them.

Removing staff from exhibition spaces is unlikely the solution for increasing immersion. Instead, the situation becomes another case where the needs of logistics, safety, and immersion must be balanced with one another. If we want guests to take part in playful behavior, they need to feel safe. This means ensuring that the physical environment is logistically safe to interact with and creating a social environment where trying out new things is safe and comfortable. As mentioned before, offering the guests alibis for interaction can be a way around the awkwardness of acting in an unusual way or trying out new things. Therefore, increasing the number or strength of the alibis may help in creating an environment where new roles and actions can be tested without the fear of embarrassment despite the presence of staff or other guests. An alibi could be included in exhibition texts, or in other elements of the physical space. In Courage, Freedom, Love! some of the wall texts include hints about possible interaction points, or what could even be interpreted as a permission to experience. For example, a wall text in the main room encourages its readers to go, discover, and crawl into the tent that is placed nearby. This hint, to those who read it, can act as an alibi to go and explore. The mention is short and does not read as instructions but rather an encouragement, which leaves the decision up to the guests.

Another strategy could be to use similar tools with the non-character staff, as with those working as characters. This performative labor, often seen in theme parks, is a growing trend. The employees' look and behavior is designed to be a part of the experience rather than just facilitating it. This means that the staff performs their tasks with a specific emotion, character, and presentation, much like an actor would. In some cases, this may mean focusing on your display of emotions and performing positivity, while other times, such as some theme parks, the employee may have a more specific character to play while carrying out their other duties.[165] While performing a character may not always be possible in terms of logistics or practicality, if the staff appears to exist within the magic circle and be involved in the story world, their presence might become a more natural part of the experience. Depending on the situation, the staff could be used in modeling behavior expected on the experience site. As

[165] Younger, "*Theme Park Design*", 227.

will be discussed in chapter 3.2.1., actors can be used in modelling potentially embarrassing behavior, or in inviting guests to explore and interact with the space around them.[166] While not always directly applicable, these and other strategies could be modified to be utilized by non-character staff as well to encourage guests to explore without breaking their immersion.

Adults visiting themed and immersive spaces, or almost any space, with small children have an added role and a point of interaction. They guide the child through the space, point out things to do, and explain some of the thematic components to them. In a way, the adult is helping to bridge a gap between the designer and the child. The designers' cues for what there is to do in a space get forwarded through an adult to a child who may have otherwise missed them. This was especially apparent in the Moominhouse in Moominworld, where there were a lot of objects that were foreign to modern children, such as a spinning wheel for yarn. However, in some places it can be questioned whether an adult should need to translate the designer's intention for the child. Of course, younger children will often need help in making sense of the world around them, but at times it could be made easier through additional visual cues. Perhaps there could be a picture of a character using the spinning wheel to help in prompting an action from a guest. Moominworld efficiently uses actors for this purpose in many of the locations, though there were not any inside of the Moominhouse's upper floors, which are much smaller spaces compared to those outdoors, which makes them a challenge, or even a hazard, for the bigger fur-characters.

An adult exploring a space with a child is acting as a guide similarly to one that might lead an excursion into an unknown environment. A good guide can connect a guest to their physical environment through stories and knowledge, and offer an experience that matches each guests needs and preferences.[167] At times, in-character staff can fulfill this role, but it was apparent that many parents naturally started narrating the Moomin stories that they had read with their children, or drawing their attention to unfamiliar things and explaining how they connected to Moomins, or what they could be used for. This added interaction and expansion of the world can make the child's experience more immersive as they discover new information and opportunities. As mentioned, coming to the space with a child acts an alibi for interaction, as does play itself.[168] Based on the observations it seems that playing with a child diminishes or

[166] Stenros, "Between Game Facilitation and Performance," 81.; Machon, *"Immersive Theatres"*, 215.

[167] Tarssanen "*Elämystuottajan käsikirja*", 25.

[168] Stenros, "Playfulness", at 30:20.

changes the social expectations for adult behavior, and therefore encourages play and interaction. Additionally, the social rule of it being okay to play with children gives the adult an opportunity to explore the space themselves.

Even if children are not present, multiple people joining an activity together can draw other people in and create a situation where the majority sets a new social norm. Once a playful mindset turns into play shared with others, it can also attract those who are not in a playful mindset themselves, since the structure of play means that after some time, it can occur independently from playfulness.[169] Whether in a playful mindset or not, seeing others enjoying an activity functions as an incentive to participate. Lohikoski recognizes this as one of the main tools for getting people to join into activities. When they see others having fun, they are inclined to join, and the experience becomes a shared moment between multiple guests.[170]

3.2.1. Actors

Actors can be an effective strategy in bringing a space alive and offering guests chances for interaction. Out of the two case studies only Moominworld uses live actors in their spaces. Although, Reichstein says that he considers the exhibition guests to become almost like actors themselves as they enter the story world.[171] This chapter will focus on the in-character staff working in Moominworld, and the use of actors in themed and immersive experiences in general.

Some of Moominworld's characters are fur-characters unable to speak, while some perform without a mask, allowing them to talk directly with the guests and other characters.[172] They are a major part of the experience, and many come to the park looking for their favorites. In the park you often hear people looking for their favorite characters or wondering which ones they may have missed. Some of the park's areas are built specifically for a certain character to inhabit. Through them, the presence of a character can be felt even when they are elsewhere.

[169] Ibid., at 15:00.

[170] Lohikoski, interview.

[171] Reichstein, interview.

[172] Lohikoski, interview.



Figure 3. Moominworld, Moomin - a fur-character - in front of the Moominhouse.
© Moomin Characters™
Theme Park Creared by Dennis Livson



Figure 4. Moominworld, Snufkin - a speaking character – in his camp.
© Moomin Characters™
Theme Park Creared by Dennis Livson

The work of these characters can be understood through two other contexts where actors are often used: living history museums and LARP. Both are themed and immersive spaces, one of which is built around historical sites and the other can be any fictional or historical world.

Scott A Lukas interviewed Past Pleasures Ltd's Managing and Artistic Director Mark Wallis regarding performing and interpreting spaces in his book The Immersive Worlds Handbook: Designing Theme Parks and Consumer Spaces. While he mainly speaks of using actors in historical reconstruction, some of his points are very transferable to the use of actors in spaces built around existing fictive worlds. According to Wallis, working in historical costumes can

be physically tiring and mentally exhausting, and since the reconstructions do not use scripts, the actors need to be able to improvise and correctly play the part.[173] The same is true for the characters in Moominworld. Many of the costumes are heavy fabrics and can be especially hot and uncomfortable during hot summer days. Much like in the case of a historical character, many of the guests know exactly how a certain Moomin character should behave and, for example, who they are friends with. The actors need to be able to improvise while following the rules set by the source material. In Moominworld, the performers do have some scripts to support their work. Still, in the scripts for shorter events there is space left for improvisation to better answer to possible input from the guests.[174] Leaving space for audience interaction within these events allows for further engagement and rewards the guests for interaction through more personalized experiences.

Not all events are scheduled and told about beforehand. Lohikoski describes them not only as events, but as tools given to the performers to help with the intensive work. Being able to follow what Lohikoski describes a "hidden script", offers them a chance to take a break from full-on improvisation and instead engage the audience with an event that seems like a spontaneous decision made by the character.[175] An example of this would be Pyykkiorkesteri, which happened to occur during the observation period. Little My came to Mrs Fillyjonk's yard, where her cleaning station is. Children play there a lot, as it is one of the interactive attractions in the park, so she easily got a crowd together to start an orchestra playing cleaning supplies. The event was naturally ended, as Mrs Fillyjonk returned home acting shocked, prompting Little My to apologize for the mess and gather the supplies with the children. Both actions are very character-typical so the event seemed like something that could naturally happen in the Moominvalley, allowing the children to feel like they were in the story world, and now a crucial part of a major event.

Only some of the character-led events are scheduled and included in the guide provided to the guests.[176] This can make the un-scheduled events feel more authentic and make the guest feel special about having been part of something spontaneous. However, this means that there is the risk of another guest being disappointed if they arrive right as an event is ending or hear

[173] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 96.

[174] Lohikoski, interview.

[175] Ibid.

[176] Ibid.

about it afterwards. These guests can be met by the characters and receive personal interaction instead. This responsibility and challenge to meet everyone is highlighted during days when the park is full, since many guests are excited about meeting the characters. As with any personalized interaction point, the actors run a risk of becoming a bottle neck.[177]

Lohikoski highlights the characters' importance in engaging guests and cuing actions that rope them further into the story.[178] This is similar to immersive theatre experiences, where actors can invite guests to enter the story world with them and interact with it further.[179] Characters may tell secrets or give missions to children. Lohikoski emphasizes the opportunities of personalization this creates. For example, Muddler, a character in the park, might whisper a secret to a child and ask them to deliver the message to his son Sniff, who can also be found in the park. This is something private, and the child gets to feel special, and like the experience is only for them, which creates a wow moment.[180] Being partial to secret knowledge and participating in a one-on-one situation with a performer are recognized by Biggin as a tool for making a compelling immersive experience.[181] This is something that can also be achieved through environmental storytelling or a well-hidden element that only a few would find, but using actors gives the experience more control over them. The characters interacting with guests and creating these one-on-one moments are a tool that Moominworld, though a mass experience, can use in creating personalized moments for individuals.[182]

The characters in Moominworld can bring guests into the story through interaction. Directly inviting people to come play a game, form an orchestra or join for a walk immediately involves them in the world and breaks the division between a performer and an audience member, rather making them co-existing characters within the same story world. These interactions change the narrative of the guests experience, making them a strong example of explicit interaction, which is one of the categories of narrative interaction by Salen and Zimmerman.[183] Explicit interaction is also possible through the choices made regarding the

[177] Younger, "*Theme Park Design*", 227.

[178] Lohikoski, interview.

[179] Machon, "*Immersive Theatres*", 215.

[180] Lohikoski, interview.

[181] Biggin, "*Immersive Theatre*", 85 & 90.

[182] Lohikoski, interview.

[183] Biggin, "*Immersive Theatre*", 89-90.

paths guests choose to follow and their engagement with physical objects.[184] However, the actors are often able to make these moments more personalized.

Actors can be an efficient way to invite guests to further engage with the world. Despite this, not every guest necessarily wants to take every opportunity for further engagement. Wallis highlights the actors' skill in reading the room. As they greet the guest the first time, the actor can tell whether they want to engage more with the performance, or not.[185] A similar responsibility falls to the characters in Moominworld. Some of them, such as the Witch, might be scary to smaller children, and some guests are shy by nature. For the experience to stay comfortable for everyone, a character needs to be able to adjust their performance to suit each guest. Lohikoski recognizes this as one of the challenging parts of the characters' job. She adds that on top of the training the performers receive before starting, the challenging situations are also worked on with them during the season to support their work.[186] In addition to reading the situation to keep it comfortable for the guest, actors in themed and immersive experiences can at times support the logistical needs of the experience through situational awareness. This includes reading the situation in terms of time spent with each guest, which can help in controlling capacity, as it may be at odds with creating truly interactive moments for a large number of guests.[187]

As mentioned, the actors' functions can be understood through LARP. While roleplaying, each player has their own character, but to understand the position of an actor placed by a designer, we can look at non-player characters (NPC) that can be used in live-action roleplaying games. Jaakko Stenros has recognized six functions performed by what he calls ractors, which are interactive actors performing non-player characters in a LARP. These functions are facilitating, content creation, character portrayal, entertaining, playing, and safeguarding.[188] It is interesting to look at these functions in another environment. Of course, the relationship between a ractor and a player in a LARP, and the one between a character and a guest in Moominworld is different, but the framework is still useful in understanding the

[184] Ibid., 89.

[185] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 97.

[186] Lohikoski, interview.

[187] Younger, "*Theme Park Design*", 227.

[188] Stenros, "Between Game Facilitation and Performance," 76.

characters' importance for the space in a more rounded way rather than only through what is directly perceived by a guest.

In LARPs, the ractors can be used as a tool for runtime game-mastering, which means the organizers way of controlling the game and its players throughout the LARP.[189] As facilitators, they ensure that players receive needed information, stay on track, do not get overwhelmed by irrelevant details, and that the infrastructure around them is working as it should. If not, the ractor needs to find a work-around. They are the ones keeping contact with the game-masters, or organizers of the LARP, when possible and needed.[190]
In Moominworld, some of these tasks are not as relevant or can be taken care of by non-character staff. The world is also much more open to explore as there is no set storyline that the guests would be expected to follow. However, the characters can still participate in controlling audience flow through conversations, suggesting new locations, and covering for broken equipment. For example, Mrs Fillyjonk explained to some visiting children that a water tap at her place was broken by Stinky. As the children recognized this action to be in line with the character, it went without a question and caused them to offer insights into Stinky's location and doings. This started an additional storyline that they got to be a part of. This turned the potentially negative experience of something being broken into an added layer of a story, as it led to a sequence where the children were then sent to fetch Stinky to come attend Etiquette School, which Mrs Fillyjonk had told them that the police chief, a character in the park, had requested as a solution to the water tap being broken. Both of these additional characters were present at the park, and the children could really go talk to them about what had happened and create a new story within the park that affected how the situation was solved.

This chain of events ties to other roles as well, such as content creation and entertainment, but it serves as an example of a way a character can work around broken equipment or other challenges, such as crowding, by using existing plot lines and character profiles known by many guests. It shows how actors, when working as facilitators, can contribute to functional interaction. Interestingly, in this example the situation became more of an explicit interaction, as the broken equipment started a chain reaction that led to a new narrative being born, and

[189] Ibid., 77-78.

[190] Ibid., 80-81.

for multiple guests to experience a personalized interaction involving multiple characters, even if all of them were not physically present as the moment started. It is common for the characters to keep up the story of the Moominvalley living its own life around the visitors by speaking of other characters whom they have met, what they have done, and explaining things happening around the park through the existing narrative. In this situation the habit of involving other characters turned a potential break in immersion into an opportunity for further immersion instead.

In any situation, the characters speaking of one another give them the opportunity to tell the guests more about the world surrounding them. Stenros sees the tasks of teaching players about the game world and showing its norms by setting an example as a part of ractors' role as facilitators. They become a way of showing rather than telling and can offer social alibis by modelling potentially embarrassing actions first.[191] They can act as an alibi for interaction by setting an example and giving out tasks to do in the world. This is the same for the characters working in Moominworld, and actors in many other themed and immersive spaces. As natives to the story world, they can show accepted behaviors and suggest to the guests what to do next if they are not sure what to choose, or what there is to choose from. This can assist in the task of ensuring a guest, or a player in the case of ractors, does not become overwhelmed by their environment.

Simultaneously, the actors take part in another function recognized by Stenros: content creation. Through their performance, whether in a LARP or another themed and immersive experience, they create content for the guests. Stenros points out that while there may be scripted moments, phrases or monologues prepared for some campaigns, much of the content creation is done through improvisation. [192] As was discussed earlier in this chapter, this is also true for the characters in Moominworld, who mostly rely on improvisation, although they can at times use a hidden script to draw an event. Additionally, they are performing fleshed-out and well-known characters, so many mannerisms, patterns of speech, and topics can be drawn from the source material, though it also creates challenges and limitations to how each character can be performed.

[191] Ibid., 81.

[192] Ibid., 82.

Character portrayal on its own is one of the six functions recognized by Stenros.[193] The selection of characters for the theme park is different from that of a LARP. In LARP, the characters are built around the functional needs of the game.[194] In Moominworld, the characters are chosen from the original source material, and their main purpose is not to fulfill a functional need. In both cases, the actors come from different backgrounds and levels of previous acting experience.[195] In Moominworld, the character portrayal's importance is highlighted. The characters bring the world alive and can make it feel like the events within the experience are personal and not planned beforehand.[196] It was clear during the observation period that to many guests the characters are precisely what they have come to look for. Many physical areas are built to represent one of the characters, such as Snufkin's camp or Mrs Fillyjonk's house.

Additionally, the actors can provide entertainment for the guests. Entertainment is one of the remaining functions recognized by Stenros. In a LARP, entertainment can mean providing structure, playing the parts that would not be enjoyable or meaningful for a player to have, or keeping players engaged and entertained during slower periods or maintenance breaks.[197] In Moominworld, entertainment becomes a lot about conversations had with the guests, playful moments, events, and tasks given out. It is a way to personalize the experience. For many guests it means the opportunity to hug or take a photograph with their favorite characters. Compared to a LARP, the characters in a theme park do not have the need to control the guests' journeys, but they can offer alternatives.

Apart from initiating storylines or quests, the characters are able to keep the park alive beyond what can be seen. They can tell stories about characters who may not be present or whom the visitors missed. The characters' interactions with one another bring in another layer of immersion, as they stay in character and maintain the known relationships between one another even when there is seemingly no audience. Additionally, they encourage further exploration when telling the visitors about areas they may not have yet seen or encouraging

[193] Ibid., 83.

[194] Ibid.

[195] Ibid., 79 & 83.; Lohikoski, interview.

[196] Lohikoski, interview.

[197] Stenros, "Between Game Facilitation and Performance," 85.

them to seek out and interact with other characters, as was done in the case of Mrs Fillyjonk and the broken water tap.

The next function recognized by Stenros is play, which is where the difference between a LARP and a theme park in terms of the actors' experience becomes apparent. In a LARP, a ractor will still be participating in the game, and is balancing between facilitating it for the others and getting carried away with playing themselves. In some cases, the ractors may choose not to know something about the game, such as a solution to a puzzle, to be better able to participate themselves.[198] It is this opportunity of participation that sets the ractors clearly apart from the actors.

The characters in Moominworld meet and greet a larger volume of guests compared to the number of players a ractor would typically interact with. With the characters in the theme park, there is a much stronger audience-performer dynamic, which separates the characters from the guests. In LARPs, the players, having signed up as such, would likely be more aware of their positioning as co-creators with the ractors, which further changes the dynamic and shifts it away from the audience-performer one. There are still moments when a character in Moominworld is acting more as a player rather than a facilitator. They may be immersed in the world as a character, though it is not fully comparable to the experience of a ractor getting to immerse themselves in the game as a player. This is further emphasized by the theme park being open daily for a three-month long season, during which the characters perform in a similar environment every day due to there not being a larger narrative progression between them. The characters need to stay the same and follow the set source material. Their story does not noticeably progress, nor do they go through any major character development, unlike a character played by a ractor might in a LARP.[199]

The final function Stenros recognized is that of safeguarding.[200] He brings up the balancing act between keeping a game believable, but safe.[201] In Moominworld the characters do not carry as big of a responsibility over matters of safety, or perceived safety, as the ractors in the LARPs Stenros studies. They do, of course, need to consider the aspects of safe and

[198] Ibid., 86.

[199] Ibid., 90.

[200] Ibid., 86.

[201] Ibid., 86-87.

comfortable interactions with guests and each other. A significant part of their responsibility is to one another. Since the fur-characters cannot use their own voices, the speaking characters interpret for them when necessary. They can also end an interaction if needed and give an in-character explanation to the guests why a character needs to leave. This way they can stay safe, but the illusion does not break.

The characters carry a responsibility for keeping the experience believable and following the guidelines set by the source material. Character-appropriate behavior is a key in an experience where many of the guests are familiar with the story world and its inhabitants, so everything needs to be done in accordance with the work of Tove Jansson. This must be done with the character and guest safety in mind, without forgetting the other functions of an in-character staff member. The characters keep the world alive, and offer the guests something to search for, which drives them to explore the physical environment. This came up during the observation period, when a great example of the characters effect on guests, in this case me, occurred.

During the first observation period I experienced a surprisingly strong reaction to seeing Thingumy and Bob in the distance while being stuck in a labyrinth I had entered moments earlier. These are two characters I had not met in the park during my childhood, and that I have a personal connection to. This caused me to race for an exit to be able to confirm I had seen right before the characters could move elsewhere. The unexpected strong emotional connection combined with a challenging physical environment and a reward became a fun and fond memory. It shows that the characters can not only provide interactivity and personalization, but they are also a strong incentive to explore the physical space, while simultaneously functioning as a reward for doing so.

3.3. The Space as a Guide and a Stage

The two case studies, Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love!, are located in very different environments. Moominworld is on an island in the middle of a nature area surrounded by the old town of Naantali with its wooden houses and cobble roads. Courage, Freedom, Love! takes place in the Maritime Museum of Finland, which is located within the Maritime Centre Vellamo in the Old Port of Kotka surrounded by stone buildings and

industrial sites. The exhibition is at the very end of the Maritime Center requiring the guests to walk through other exhibition spaces displaying historical stories, old transportation vessels, and other exhibitions that unrelated to the Moomin world. It is separated from the rest of them by glass doors and has a much shorter time to transport its guests to the story world compared to Moominworld which welcomes its guests through a bridge and a forest pathway. Lohikoski describes this bridge as a transitional space between our world and the story world.[202]



Figure 5. Lukas Jokilehto, The Bridge to Moominworld, 2025.

Entrance areas are a key component of immersive experiences. They communicate to the guest about the type of place they are about to enter and are one of the first physical spaces to be put to the test in terms of expectation management. Well-designed transitional spaces are one of the key elements of themed and immersive spaces.[203] A good entrance area should give the guests a feeling of truly entering another world.[204] In this case, they are moving from the real world to the Moomin world.

The entrance area's effect can be maximized by using exciting visual elements.[205] This is slightly easier for Moominworld as the natural environment of Naantali offers beautiful sea views and the bridge as a connection point to the island serves as an exciting and clear transitional space. In the case of Courage, Freedom, Love! the analysis of the entrance is dependent on which point is seen as the entrance. The exhibition starts immediately after class

[202] Lohikoski, interview.

[203] Lukas, "Why Immersion Matters", 126.

[204] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 145.

[205] Ibid.

doors separating it from the rest of the Maritime Center, where the guests are greeted by a wall text and a large glass ball that shows life in the Moominvalley. However, this does not yet feel like a part of the Moomin world but instead an introductory space still connected to the world of the Maritime Center.



Figure 6. Alexander Reichstein, The First Room of Courage, Freedom, Love!.

A much more natural and efficient entrance area to the world of Moomins is behind a half-wall, where the guest is led through a dark forest. This fulfils the expectation of an entrance being visually interesting and acts as a darker buffer between the Maritime Centre and the Moominvalley, which the guests enter after the narrow forest section. This forest hallway already has some display cases introducing Moomin characters, as well as multiple animations, so there is not a similar transition phase leading up to the world as there is in Moominworld, where the guests wander through a short forest path. This can work in the exhibition's favor, as when the guests enter the theme park, there is a merchandise and restaurant area between them and Moomin Valley. This may partially disconnect the immersion that was born during the journey across the water and forest, as the shops and restaurants, while themed, do not really fit the story world that the guests are entering through them. While the start of the experience is very different between the two case studies, both use similar elements in bringing their guests in and into the correct mindset. They have narrow entrances separating the main areas from the everyday world that the guests come from, and both open up to a familiar view of the Moominvalley with the Moominhouse acting as an attractor pulling them in.

These attractors, sometimes called wienies in the context of Disney, are elements "deliberately positioned and framed to motivate guest movement towards it, though they do not necessarily have to be icons." [206] In both case studies, Moominhouse works as an attractor to pull the guests deeper into the main areas, which in both cases are the first wider areas the guests encounter, if the restaurant area in the theme park is not considered. Designer John Hench has called them "visual magnets". This describes well their purpose of leading guests by showing them something visually interesting that pulls them in to explore it further.[207]

Attractors are one element used in wayfinding, which means the use of physical elements in orientating the guests. Guests can be led by the pathways, other people and characters, signs, or a map. Placing further attractions in a way that allows guests to see them while approaching can offer a point of interest and a clear goal for the guests to move towards. This is not only important for the guests to know where to go, but to create a sense of excitement and feeling of there being something to discover.[208] Clarity about wayfinding supports functional interactivity. Still, many theme parks avoid using the clearest option, signage, for all their communication and instead go for other options, such as attractors, that do not have as striking visual impact. [209]

When needed, the negative impact of signage can be lessened by using diegetic or semi-diegetic signs, which can even add an element of thematic storytelling to the space.[210] Diegetic signs are ones that could appear in the story world, and semi-diegetic ones could have been put together by its residents. These are limited by the options offered by the source material, and other visual theming chosen for the attraction. [211] In the world of Moomins, written instructional signs appear rarely, which makes it more challenging to have diegetic signs within the themed and immersive experiences built around it without them appearing as an element of our own world rather than that of Moomins. There are some semi-diegetic signs used in the theme park but in most cases, wayfinding is supported either by other means or

[206] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 182.; Younger, "*Theme Park Design*", 339.

[207] Younger, "*Theme Park Design*", 252.

[208] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 139.

[209] Younger, "*Theme Park Design*", 252.

[210] Ibid., 206.

[211] Ibid.

extra-diegetic signs, which are ones that would not appear in the story world at all. Most of these were in connection with places that would not appear in the Moomin world, such as the gift shop and the restaurants, and their placement kept them mostly separate from the heavily immersive attractions further in the park. Lohikoski points out that Moominworld does not need to explicitly direct their guests, as they tend to naturally find their way to the attraction points, and the theme park specifically wants to offer them the freedom to explore without being taken through the park in a specific pattern.[212] This allows for the guests to see the separate areas within the park in the order they themselves choose.

These separate attractions, often living spaces built around different characters, offer the guests the episodic nature often connected to spatial stories.[213] This structure, often used in games, means that the guests can encounter the areas in any order without it significantly impacting the experience as a whole. Jenkins talks about this as enacting stories, meaning that the narrative progresses through the character's, or in this case the guest's, movement through the area. Though Jenkins' work sees it from the perspective of games, the structure fits in the discussion of themed and immersive spaces in the physical world as well. Spatial stories that privilege exploration over plot development are held together by broader goals and conflicts.[214] In the themed and immersive experiences looked at in this study, these goals and conflicts become even broader due to the individual nature of them. While one guest might aim to find a specific character, another is there to learn more about Moomins, and the third to keep their children safe and enjoy the visual environment. More specific storylines may be added through personal goals or tasks given by the characters, as was discussed in chapter 3.2.1.

Even without the characters, the spaces tell stories in both Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love! The boiling potatoes in the Moominhouse's kitchen, the gear at Snufkins camp, and other details in each room and attraction tell stories of the characters' lives and create a sense of presence even when they are not there. This can be especially useful in places such as Courage, Freedom, Love! that rely on spatial storytelling rather than adding actors beyond the guests themselves. These details bring in an added element of embedded

[212] Lohikoski, interview.

[213] Jenkins, "Game Design" 7-8.

[214] Ibid., 8.

narratives, which allows guests to piece together stories through discovering clues in the environment.[215] While in these experiences there is no one great storyline, like in many of the games where this structure is used, it still allows the guests to figure out things about the characters and what they have been up to. Jenkin describes games using embedded structures as open-ended and exploratory narrative structures where the story is more of a body of information rather than a temporal structure.[216] This description matches many themed and immersive experiences, making it interesting to consider them through the lens of game design. Embedded narratives, enacting stories, and evocative spaces all offer tools in understanding these physical spaces and can help in creating experiences with the guest in focus, almost as if they were a character playing a game.

There are some things that are hard to build. The nature surrounding Moominworld is one of them. According to Lohikoski, the island nature surrounding the theme park makes the experience especially unique, and on top of that the nature of Kailo Island resembles closely that of the Moominvalley further helping with the immersion. Nature becomes an experience on its own, and to some visitors it can even be exotic. Nature fills the areas where no sound design has been made, and creates a soundscape of birds singing, waves hitting the shore, and wind blowing, making itself a part of the story world.[217]

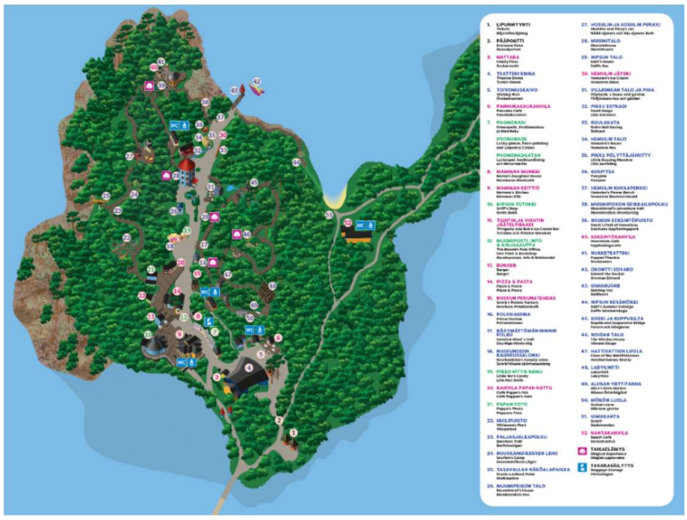


Figure 7. Moominworld, Map of Moominworld.
© Moomin Characters™
Theme Park Creared by Dennis Livson

[215] Ibid., 10.

[216] Ibid.

[217] Lohikoski, interview.

The nature surrounding the park creates a barrier between Moominworld and the everyday world. The guests can explore the island without stumbling across a scenery jarringly different from the expected nature of the Moominvalley. They can even swim in the ocean, which adds another interaction point that is in line with the story of Moomins, who are known to spend time swimming in the ocean themselves. Though the Moomins at the park do not swim, the visitors can. Nature does its part in keeping the world alive and providing additional characters to the story. According to Lohikoski, every now and then a guest might see a fox, a bunny, or a snake. Of course, nature can cause seemingly negative situations, such as a storm. However, storms are a keen part of the Moomin world, and therefore do not necessarily break immersion, though they can discourage active exploration of the outdoor space.

Moominworld is built in a way that allows operations to continue even during rainfall. Moomins can put their rain gear on, and continue playing in the rain, jumping in the puddles and keeping up with the adventurous and happy atmosphere despite the weather. If a proper storm were to strike, the guests and characters can gather in the Moominhouse to keep rain or do something else that fits the moment.[218] The nature and the Moomin narrative work together in a way that allows for immersion even when the weather is unideal. While the park's outdoor location does create its own challenges, the choice of location on the island supports the narrative even through challenges.

In Courage, Freedom, Love!'s case, the original room division at the National Museum, seen in figure 8, was determined by the existing space. According to Reichstein, the rooms available happened to fit well, and the idea of how to divide them was born as soon as he saw the space, since there was a suitable number of different kinds of rooms. The space in Maritime Centre Vellamo is smaller than the exhibition's original space at the National Museum, as is seen in figures 8 and 9. This meant that not all features, such as a moving theatre stage, could be included in the second iteration of the exhibition. The stage itself is present, but only static. Other missing features, due to space-related or other limitations, include a bonfire to burn prohibition signs to mimic a scene from the Moomin books, and an array of snowballs that could be built with.[219]

[218] Ibid.

[219] Reichstein, interview.



Figure 8. Alexander Reichstein, Illustration of Courage, Freedom, Love!'s first iteration that was exhibited at the National Museum of Finland in 2020-2021.

The changes made to the space should not be seen as negative, as willingness to change is a key element of immersion, as identified by Lukas.[220] While he mostly talks about change in order to keep things new and exciting, and adapt to guests' needs and wants as they change with time, the willingness to change an existing design to bring it to a new space and audience should also be considered in this category. Rather than force all existing elements in and risk overwhelming the guests, adaptations can help in keeping the space functional and immersive even in a new environment.

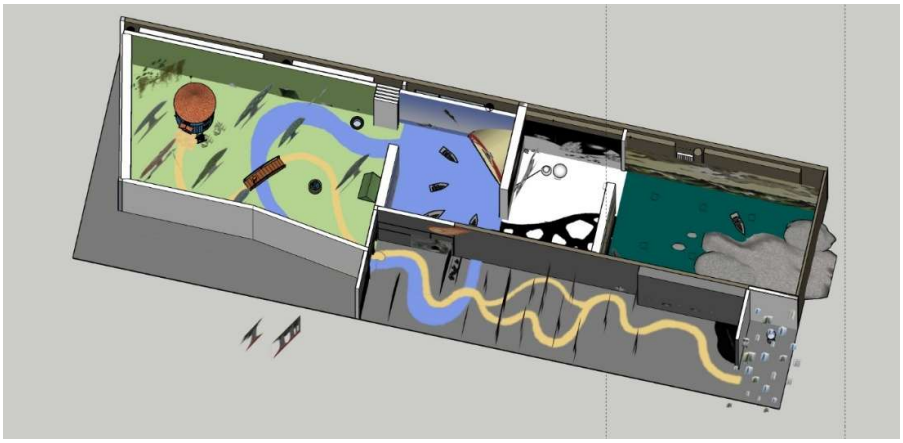


Figure 9. Alexander Reichstein, Illustration of Courage, Freedom, Love!'s second iteration that opened at the Maritime Museum of Finland in 2025.

[220] Lukas, "Why Immersion Matters", 126.

Courage, Freedom, Love! being housed in an exhibition space means that it has the potential to have very different immersive microenvironments very close together while causing minimal visual interruptions to one another. However, it means that the transitions between spaces are short and do not allow for as smooth of a transition than those presented in Moominworld due to their wide in-nature location. Similarly, the transition to the world of Moomins at the exhibition can appear more jarring, as one passes other exhibitions including a collection of large boats and other vessels, that draw attention to themselves. This is somewhat combated by the exhibition having its own entrance space and leading its guests into the Moominvalley through a narrow pathway in a dark forest.

Thematically the location in a Maritime Museum is very accurate and the vessels that the audience see on their way to the exhibition fall into the larger narrative of all things ocean, that also relates to the world of Moomins. The exhibition is hinted at by a couple of Moomin-themed signs on the way to the exhibition, helping visitors to focus on the correct world among the different exhibitions. This is of course different depending on whether the visitor has come to the Maritime Centre for the Moomins specifically, or if they happen to come across it while exploring another exhibition, or the Maritime Centre as a whole. The situation is very different compared to Moominworld which is isolated on an island.

Both Courage, Freedom, Love! and Moominworld are based on the existing story world created by Tove Jansson. Both experience spaces pay special attention to respecting the original material and its values in their design. Based on the interviews, it seems that most of their guests are at least somewhat familiar with the Moomin world before entering these spaces, though the level of knowledge varies from people who have just been introduced to it to those who know almost everything there is to know. [221] Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love! are evocative spaces, as described by Jenkins, that allow the guests to interpret a space built around a familiar story by reading it against their pre-existing knowledge and associations.[222] This means that the designers do not need to spend as much time introducing the guests to a new world. However, it leaves the guests at a somewhat inequal position in terms of discovery and interpreting cues.

[221] Lohikoski, interview.; Reichstein, interview.

[222] Jenkins, ”Game Design”.

For example, a sound that drew me to explore Invisible Ninni's Trail, which will be further discussed in chapter 3.3.1., would most likely not have caused such a strong and immediate need for exploration in someone who did not recognize it, or someone to whom the character it is related to was not important. The sound, due to its quietness and only occasional appearance, would be unlikely to cause any negative reactions even in those guests, but it would not fulfill its potential. An option would be to introduce each guest to the characters whose territory they are about to enter to make them more receptive to the cues offered. Although, this would break the immersion of the guests being in the real Moominvalley, as the characters would not have signs explaining who they are or videos of themselves in their homes. This approach could work in the exhibition space of Courage, Freedom, Love!, or a similar space, where the representational nature of the space is more forthcoming.

Perhaps an exhibition text or a guide could introduce the guests to a story of a character to guide their attention to looking for sounds or sights related to them. Much like every creak and sigh of a forest feels much more prominent and personal after listening to a horror story, the elements of an immersive space could be heightened by leveling the amount of previous knowledge the guests have and hinting at what to look for. Using a tactic like this does not work for every space. It limits the possibility for guests to make independent discoveries that lead to more meaningful and personalized moments. It seems that both case studies in this thesis have chosen to let the guests find and miss things on their own accord, rather than guiding them into looking for something specific.

Being previously familiar with the world changes the way guests look at it. Perhaps they have a favorite character and are eager to search far and wide to find them, which leads them to further discoveries on the way. A great example from Moominworld is a little girl, who wanted to see Snufkin and knew that he, as a character, was often associated with hiking and nature. Therefore, she took a heading towards what she deemed to be the more wooded side of the park, following what she felt would have been a likely pathway for the character to take. She did, in fact, end up in Snufkin's camp. This ability to think like the character and end up in the right place shows that the placement was quite intuitive and in line with the story world. This can be especially powerful, though it must be remembered that people's level of previous knowledge varies. It may be that a guest does not have a specific goal in mind while entering the park. They may end up looking for points of interest on the map, following the group they are with, or simply wandering among the other guests. For them, it

may be more difficult to get existed about the hidden camp or the Witch's Hut until they actually discover it. This can pose a risk of boredom or missed discoveries, especially if the guest is not relying on the map.

Both Reichstein and Lohikoski bring up their adult guests who have extensive knowledge of the Moomin world through the books and animations. Lohikoski mentions that the countless details in Moominworld offer experiences for these guests as well, even if nothing is completely new, as many guests enjoy visuality and looking for details.[223] Their expertise not only brings them to the park, but drives them to explore further and focus on the smaller details. Reichstein takes up the need to design content for these expert guests to enjoy in an exhibition. He gives a concrete example of feedback from the museum's leadership that he received during the design process of the first Courage, Freedom, Love! exhibition at the National Museum. While the plentiful interactive elements were seen as great for children, there was the question of what an adult, who has already read all the Moomin books and wants deeper information, could discover from the exhibition. This feedback led to the creation of the glass display cases that became an essential part of the exhibition.[224]

The display cases include information on the creation of the Moomins, specific characters, and the life of Tove Jansson. Reichstein describes their appeal as an opportunity to learn. The displays are especially valuable to those who already know a lot about Moomins yet still want to learn more. The curiosity and want to expand their knowledge can draw them to reading further than what the wall texts offer. Each display case's target audience has been taken into account in their placement height. Who ends up discovering which one is partially directed by what Reichstein describes as guided chance. Displays meant mainly for adults are placed higher up, while those more suitable for children as well are placed lower.[225] There is also the addition of a small door and Moominmamma's handbag that are right on floor level that many, though not nearly all, adults missed or chose to skip during the observation. While they are presented as display cases, the information they provide is more visual and related to the story world, rather than its creation.

[223] Lohikoski, interview.

[224] Reichstein, interview.

[225] Ibid.



Figure 10. Alexander Reichstein, A Display Case in Courage, Freedom, Love!.



Figure 11. Alexander Reichstein, Moominmamma's Handbag in Courage, Freedom, Love!.

The existence of these display cases seems to function as a visual cue for adult guests to come closer and learn more. While some children were curious about them during the observation period, most did not stop to explore them further. However, many adults went naturally from display to display, much like some others followed the painted pathway on the floor. These two actions did not exclude one another, and many visitors ended up doing both at some point in their visit.

It seems that offering a clear and recognizable opportunity for learning and discovery draws guests in. The placement of some displays meant that they got less attention. Especially those placed right next to the entrance or on the front wall of the ocean room. Especially with the latter, the display cases were left somewhat on their own in terms of wayfinding. They were seen by guests who fully entered the space, as they would be seen from the lighthouse island that was the main attractor of the room. Still, many guests, especially adults, did not climb onto it, and some only watched from the doorway before turning away. This meant that they never saw the display cases, which may have offered them something more than what they could see from the doorway. There was no apparent cue leading the audience to turn around and look for the display cases. An opportunity could have been to add a further pathway, perhaps one of ice or stone to match the room's theming, to communicate to the audience the opportunity to discover something more than what they could see from the doorway.

As mentioned, the light house island, seen in figure 12. works as an invitation to come into the space. It is an example of one of the three exploration styles that Reichstein describes: following the clear pathways, going from display case to display case, or in this case to follow the space's offerings and get immersed in the story. If there is an island, the guests would climb on to it, and if there are boats in the room, they will sit in them. It is unlikely that one exploration style would work for all, and many guests mix all three styles.[226] Adding multiple different routes and possibilities for the guests to see and structure the space for themselves likely increases the chance of everyone finding a way that works for them. Reichstein also highlights the importance of freedom. Since it is one of the Moomin values, as well as important to Tove Jansson herself, its presence in exhibition space is intended to be clear to the guests.[227]

[226] Reichstein, interview.

[227] Ibid.

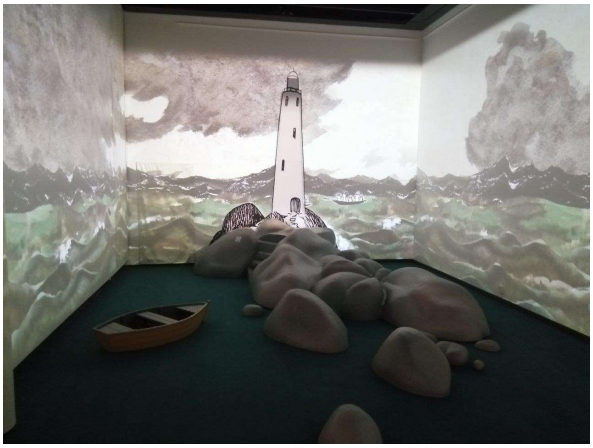


Figure 12. Alexander Reichstein, The Lighthouse Island in the Ocean Room of Courage, Freedom, Love!. The display cases would have been to the right of the photographer on the fourth wall not visible in the image.

As important it is to add positive cues into the space to help guests see its potential, attention needs to be paid to removing negative cues as well. For example, unnecessary signs, or other elements that diminish, contradict, or distract guests from the theme should be removed.[228] While instructions hidden in exhibition texts may help the guests to feel comfortable in trying out things, a balance must be found in delivering the information within the limitations set by theming. Increasing opportunities, removing barriers, and ensuring the experience can operate smoothly in terms of logistics is a challenging task. Still, even after a balance in the environment's design has been found, it remains the guests' decision whether to engage or not. A guest cannot be forced to become immersed or to engage; they can only be offered the opportunity to do so.[229]

There are situations where solutions including distractions from immersion are chosen to fulfill another goal. A curious detail at the otherwise highly immersive main body of Moominworld is a telescope installed on a cliff on the side of the island to create an interaction point called the Viewing Spot. While the telescope itself is well in-line with the environment and its narrative and even supports a story-aligned drive for discovery and exploration, its accompanying sign partially pulls it away from the story world. However, it also connects the summer resident to the Moomin world.

[228] Pine and Gilmore, "*The Experience Economy*," 55.

[229] Biggin, "*Immersive Theatre*", 62.; Reichstein, interview.

The telescope is pointed across the sea, and a sign next to it is encouraging the visitors to look if the flag is flying at the top of the tower of the summer residence Kultaranta belonging to the President of Finland. The flag being up means that the president is currently at Kultaranta. It feels curious that a world that is so well protected from the outside world for breaking its immersion would then purposefully leave open a window to a clear disruption of its own narrative. Nevertheless, the Viewing Spot's information sign functions as a connection between the President and Moominworld, bringing the summer residence into the Moomin world rather than including it as a completely outside element. It tells the visitor that Kultaranta holds the Key to Moominworld, which is given to distinguished guests who have visited Moominworld. These recipients are then named honorary citizens of Moominworld.[230]

The addition of this Viewing Spot is curious due to the theme park's insistence on keeping the real world, including politics, outside of its borders. It only came up after the interviews, but Lohikoski answered an email sent to her afterwards regarding the Viewing Spot. She specifies that initiative for the information sign and the telescope came from Moominworld. The president is, in fact, the nearest neighbor to the Kailo Island and Moominworld. [231] Lohikoski points out that Kultaranta, the president's summer residence, is culture historically remarkable and offers added value both to national and especially international guests and therefore deserves to be highlighted. Additionally, the choice of including the information sign and the telescope supports one of Moominworld's core values: education. The addition of the telescope brings a new interactive element that supports an educational element within the theme park. It strengthens Moominworld's existence within the realm of education in the model made by Pine and Gilmore.[232] It is interesting, then, that it is educating the guests on a topic not related, nor even existent, within the story world they are visiting.

It seems that the goals of immersing the guest in Moominworld and educating them about important historical topics within their immediate surroundings are contradicting one another. An added element to be taken into consideration is the value choice of supporting education, which seems to override the goal of minimizing interruptions to immersion in this specific case. Such choices become relevant in many situations when designing immersive and

[230] Moominworld, The Viewing Spot, information sign at the Moominworld theme park in Naantali, Finland, observed by the author on June 26th, 2025.

[231] Ida-Maria Lohikoski, email to author, November 14th, 2025.

[232] Pine and Gilmore, "*The Experience Economy*," 30-32.

interactive experiences. Logistics and loyalty to the source material may be at odds with one another. For example, this is the case with the need to use QR codes or the Magic Bracelets to access spaces and activities otherwise unachievable in a story world where digital solutions do not exist. The value question being a supporting factor in opening the world up to an outside element is an interesting, and surely a common discussion point in similar contradictions between goals.

The telescope is situated on the outskirts of the island with some separation to the nearest Moomin buildings. Its closest attraction is the Barefoot Trail which, while encouraging experimentation, is not strongly tied to any Moomin branding. Even one of the two next closest attraction, the Whileaway Park meant for resting, is not strongly tied to a specific character, though one can be heard snoring above the guests in a hammock. Many only stop by to test the telescope and then continue their journey. This may well be due to the little landing feeling like a pocket of the outside world within Moominworld. This separation from the world can act as a buffer preventing immersion from breaking.

The addition of an outside element can add value to the visit despite it being somewhat disconnected from the Moomin world. As mentioned, value-wise it fits into the story world, and its characters could use a telescope. Although in this case, seeing a character looking through a telescope to see an attraction that, to them, does not exist would break the story world's cohesion much more than the guests engaging with the telescope. But, in theory, the characters would likely know what the item is and how to use it.

Engaging in this activity, even without the connection drawn between Kultaranta and Moominworld, does not necessarily break the guests' immersion. Any theatrical representation takes part in the doubleness of the fictional world existing alongside the real one. The guests are aware of this and can still choose to believe in the fictional.[233] It is possible for a guest to become immersed in an action, such as exploration, even when they are aware of their environment being fictional.[234] These breaches to the world, such as the telescope, the gift shop, or the extra-diegetic signs bring up the importance of suspension of disbelief in all experienced based on something fictive. According to the Cambridge

[233] Biggin, "*Immersive Theatre*", 30.

[234] Ibid., 42.

Dictionary, suspension of disbelief is "the act of behaving as if you believe that what you are seeing, hearing, or reading is real or true, although you know that it is not".[235] This willingness to believe means that even if the representation of a fictional world is not perfect, and it rarely is, the guests can still choose to believe in it. Therefore, it is possible to choose interactive elements that allow for further engagement with the values and content of the story world, even if they are extra-diegetic in nature. It is then up to the guest whether they choose to engage or feel immersed in the world or the action they are performing.
You can only offer opportunities.

3.3.1. Designing Multisensory Experiences

Whether it is through light, sound, or other means, an experience designer can use different senses to focus their guests' attention on the intended targets. In an interview by Josephine Machon, Bill Mitchell and Sue Hill describe the audience being used as a camera, meaning that their attention can in a way be directed and zoomed in to help with storytelling in a space.[236] This can be achieved through the use of different senses. The most common ones used in designing a space include vision, hearing, touch, taste and smell.[237] According to Lohikoski, Moominworld's goal of evoking emotions and creating memorable experiences is done through multisensory design.[238]

Both Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love! use sound as a powerful tool in guiding the guests' attention. Both experiences have multiple ways of using sound not only to create immersion but to guide the visitor's curiosity. During the first observation session in Moominworld, perhaps the most effective cue leading to further investigation was located near the entrance to a pathway known as Invisible Ninni's Trail. It is a nature trail running between multiple attractions in the forest. Near its entrance there is a jingling sound associated with Invisible Ninni, a character in the Moomin animations. For the most part of the animation, Ninni is invisible and wears a bell to indicate her location. It is this bell that can be heard coming from the pathway. Ninni is one of the characters that cannot be met in

[235] Cambridge Dictionary, "Suspension of Disbelief," accessed January 1, 2026, https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/english/larp.

[236] Machon, "*Immersive Theatres*", 241.

[237] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 197.

[238] Lohikoski, interview.

the park, but this sound indicates their presence and invites people to go look for its source, bringing attention to the pathway. While during the second part of the observation visitors were not heard commenting on it out loud, it had a very strong effect on me during the first session, prompting a strong need to explore the pathway further as soon as possible.

The same character was heard giggling in Courage, Freedom, Love!. Once again, the sound drew people to look for its source. In this case it also brought up a possible issue with sound being used as a cue. The first two times I heard the sound it was not clear where it originated from. Even after seeing the figure that ended up being the source of the giggling, it was not fully clear that it was, in fact, the character connected to the sound. This led to some uncertainty about whether the goal of finding the sound's origin had been achieved, or if something had been missed. This confusion can risk breaking immersion, though it can have an opposite effect depending on how the guest approaches the goal of locating the sound. To some, the instinct might be to look for speakers, while others focus on finding the character as if they were hiding. In the best case the mysterious sound can lead to the feeling of achievement through discovery.

Sometimes the character behind a sound, such as laughter, is purposefully left out of reach. Moominworld has a great example of this. There is a large rock with a small cavern entrance visible to an adjacent path. When walking past, the guests hear laughter coming from the cavern. The sound is recognizable as the laugh of Stinky, a Moomin character who can be met in the park, but the areas in which he roams are not visible from the cavern entrance. This way, the character seems present in a place he is never actually seen in. This serves to liven up the area, further increase character presence, and the feeling of the Moominvalley living its own life in a less performative way. It can add some excitement or tension due to Stinky being a known crook in the Moomin stories.[239]

Due to this framing, the laughter of the character could be unsettling for children, causing them to avoid the cavern. Despite this, during the observation all visitors only noted the sound and continued onwards or attempted to get to the source of it. Especially children wanted to leave the path and crawl into the cavern to find the character and had to be prevented from

[239] "Stinky, a Loveable Rogue", Moomin.com, accessed December 30, 2025, https://www.moomin.com/en/blog/stinky/#4d52b2f2.

doing so by the adults they were with. To some this was further reason to find the character in the park, while some seemed frustrated about not being able to explore the cavern when a character they wanted to see seemed to be so close to them, yet not visible. In either case, the sound emerging from the cave told a story and made the guests feel Stinky's presence.

In addition to communicating the presence of a character or a creature, a well-designed soundscape can be used to bring a whole scene to life and pinpoint specific events within it. This is especially true for the ocean room in Courage, Freedom, Love!. It is a full room, where there is an animated ocean that stretches across all four walls. Characters on boats, or in the air, can travel between the whole sequence transferring from wall to wall, and in the middle of it all is a lighthouse with rocks where guests can sit down and watch the ocean move around them. Periodically there would also be a thunderstorm that was created through sound and change in the animation.

The ocean in its entirety has a very strong presence in the room. During observation, many guests came to see it, looked around and then returned to the previous room, as the exhibition ended in the ocean, which was a dead end. However, when a visitor did decide to stay, often after a discovery driving them to look for more, they would spend a long time in the room as there were many details to see. Some of them were connected to a sound that helped guide the guest's attention to something new happening. A good example of this is an airplane that would every now and then pass across the room. You could hear its engine running, and while you could not really hear its location, the sound would initiate a response to look for it. The sound in the ocean room is different from the other rooms both in rhythm and intensity.

Reichstein states that each room is different in terms of animations and sound to keep surprising the guests. The ocean room especially differs from the three other rooms as an all-encompassing and powerful experience after the audience has learned the rules of how the sound and environment work in the previous spaces.[240] Because of the changing soundscapes, the audience gets to be surprised and discover something new each time they enter a room. Individual sounds clearly separating from the general background noise were naturally more effective in capturing guests' attention. The airplane in the Courage, Freedom, Love!'s ocean room led many guests' eyes onto the sky and led to further discoveries ones it was noticed

[240] Reichstein, interview.

that the ocean really offered changing details both in the water and the sky. The most well-rounded experience rises from the combination of a well-designed background in a combination with sound cues intended to capture the guests' attention. These two have clear and separate purposes, and in the best cases supported one another seamlessly. The sound of an airplane's motor would have likely felt out of place if it was not surrounded by the general landscape of nature living its life around it.

Soundscapes can reward guests who choose to spend a longer time in a specific space. There is a radio in Hemulen's house in Moominworld that captured my attention during the observation period. The radio plays the news of the Moominvalley, mentioning other characters and telling stories that fit the overall atmosphere of the world. While the changing topics on the radio made it rewarding to stay in the room that otherwise had very little to interact with, it did not seem to capture the attention of most guests walking through the small house filled with butterfly displays. Perhaps the radio broadcast became more like a background soundtrack rather than drawing a lot of attention to itself. This can change if a guest walks by right as their favorite character is mentioned, or the broadcast happens to be describing events that draw them into listening further. Similarly to characters telling stories of each other, this broadcast helps in creating the feeling of the Moominvalley being alive around the guests even when no-one is looking or listening.

Sometimes sound design means choosing where to use silence and ambient sounds.[241] Lohikoski says that guests have commented on the natural soundscapes of Moominworld, as they have purposefully left some of the attractions without a man-made soundtrack. Instead, the island's nature gets to fill in the gaps naturally.[242] Since Moominworld has the benefit of being a mainly outdoor experience, they get to utilize the sounds of nature around them, as well as the benefits from the smell of the ocean and rain when it occurs. Both of these match well with the values of Moomin philosophy, such as nature and adventure, as well as the atmosphere described in the Moomin books.

On top of designed soundscapes, Moominworld uses smellscapes in their environmental design. Lohikoski mentions the smell of baked goods in the Moominhouse as an example of

[241] Machon, "*Immersive Theatres*", 95.

[242] Lohikoski, interview.

them using smells to immerse their guests.[243] While this smell was not noticed during the observation, it could have been a subconscious element, if active during the visit. Either way it is a good example of a smell being used to signal life in a building that does not always house the characters that are perceived to live in it. Courage, Freedom, Love! does not use smells specifically in its design. This decision was made right before the opening of the exhibition for the first time in 2020. The plan was to have a small hole where a guest could sense a bad smell coming from it as a reference to Stinky. This was cancelled due to worries about practical issues, such as allergies.

In addition to sound and smell, Moominworld has designed an attraction around touch. The forementioned Barefoot Trail lets guests experience the nature around them through heightened senses by taking off their socks and shoes to walk the path with added sensory elements. While this short path does not draw the guest to explore a new physical space, it has the potential to bring them more into the environment they are already in and connect with it through multiple senses. Simultaneously, the pathway works as a visual element to those who do not wish to engage with it further.

Visual elements can be used to guide the guest and work as points of interest as well as landmarks to head towards and use for navigation. In Courage, Freedom, Love!, painted pathways are used to guide the guests from one room to another. They are visually matched into each room's theming and used as a literal path that can be followed. During the observation it was clear that this was a very effective method of guiding audience movement, as both children and adults instinctively followed the painted pathways. In the snowy scene where instead of a solid path there are painted ice blocks with some space between them, multiple guests were seen jumping between them to avoid what they interpreted as water or mud. This showed a deep immersion in the environment, where the choice to believe the story of being on ice floats made the guests, both children and adults, want follow along the story by changing their own behavior to match the perceived needs of the space: to hop from one ice block to another to avoid getting wet.

Similarly, Moominworld uses wooden pathways to guide their guests. However, it is not done only as a thematic visual cue to lead them from a point of interaction to another, but carries a

[243] Ibid.

practical role of protecting the nature of the park.[244] With the volume of guests they have every year, the damage done to the natural environment of the park would be significant, if the guests were wondering in the forest without guidance. This is a good example of a situation where logistics influence the tools used for immersion, and how restrictions can lead to thematic solutions that not only improve the usability of the space, but the visuality, and guest experience as well. The wooden pathways fit the environment and make it more accessible than the natural landscape would be on its own. The pathways also increase feeling of security and safety that was discussed in chapters 2.1.5. and 3.1. The guests do not need to guess whether it is okay to go somewhere, and resources do not need to be used for figuring out opportunities for further exploration, which leaves more space to really focus on what is around them.

3.4. Digital Elements of Experience

Digital elements are one way to add depth and interactive elements to physical spaces. They can be used as a tool for personalization, and the creation of more intimate moments between the guest and the space.[245] In museums there are QR codes offering additional information, and some experiences use digital elements to create theatrical experiences in places where physical scenography or actors cannot be used. Lukas recognizes technology as a powerful method in combining immersion, excitement, authenticity, believability, and effective storytelling, though it has its risks as well.[246]

Both Moomin world and Courage, Freedom, Love! have utilized digital solutions in their designs. Moominworld utilizes technology-based bracelets that can be registered with a mobile phone. The bracelets are then used to activate different interaction points in the park. For example, a guest can answer a ringing phone in the Moominhouse, start the count-down of a space rocket, or wind an old clock. Similarly, Courage, Freedom, Love! has QR codes that activate animated sequences, click-and-point games, and other content. The use of these QR codes requires the use of a mobile phone.

[244] Ibid.

[245] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 152.

[246] Ibid., 214.

An interesting detail about these added technologies is that they are something of our world rather than the world of Moomins. Modern technology does not exist in the Moominvalley, so adding it is a risk in terms of immersion. In the case of the museum this risk is very different, as the exhibition is more clearly presented as a representation of the Moomin world rather than attempting to create full immersion. This allows them to more freely use technology to tell the story of Tove Jansson and the creation of Moomins, while still immersing their guests in the world created by the author. Meanwhile Moominworld is presented to the guest as a possibility to visit the real Moomin world described in the books and meet the real characters, which limits their options. Having QR codes in the Moominhouse, when they do not exist in the world, would break the immersion of the guest visiting the Moominvalley. This is resolved by using the Magic Bracelets which have the appearance of jewelry rather than technology and can better match the environment they are in.

There has been a conscious choice not to have the technology used by the guests through their mobile phones to allow them to focus on what's on offer in the park.[247] This supports their engagement with their environment and minimizes the risk of immersion being broken by a distraction on the phone. It ties back to the feeling of safety that Moominworld wants to create for its guests. There are no politics, news, religious discussions, or other possibly difficult conversation starters. This is being done to offer the guests a break from the everyday world and its worries.[248] Having the guests look up things on their phones would encourage interaction with the outside world instead of the story world around them. This could lead to people more commonly taking up non-Moomin related topics with others in the park and further breaking the immersion around them by changing the social environment. The use of mobile phones poses a risk of guests focusing too much on their personal devices rather than exploring the space around them.[249] Balancing the use of technology to achieve the best results with minimal negative aspects, such as distractions or technical difficulties, can be a challenge especially in spaces such as Moominworld, that is built around a fictional world that does not have mobile technology in it. Additionally, the Magic Bracelets are introduced as being magical, rather than technology-based, which helps to motivate their existence within the rules of the Moomin world.

[247] Lohikoski, interview.

[248] Ibid.

[249] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 220.

One way to minimize the distractions from mobile phones is to use another kind of interactive technology, such as the Magic Bracelets utilized by Moominworld. To use them, the guests register the bracelets either at home or when arriving to the park and fill in a short questionnaire including their age and favorite character. This information is used to offer personalized interactive experiences in the park. For example, a clock can guess your age, and a character speaking to you through an old telephone can address you by your name. [250] While the interactions can be spectated by other guests, the questionnaire allows them to offer additional value to the person who has paid for the bracelet. During the observation, the interactions made surrounding people curious, and they did not always notice the individualized nature of them. These individual experiences, while effective in creating personalized interactions, are challenging to facilitate. Lohikoski states that the system as it is with the registration will not continue and that Moominworld is actively looking into redesigning these experiences.[251]

While the QR codes in Courage, Freedom, Love! are readily available to any guest with a smart-phone and the skills to activate the code, the Magic Bracelets used in Moominworld need to be bought separately from the ticket. The bracelets are designed to activate the interaction points by tapping them on a reader similar to a contactless card reader. While an adult was sometimes needed to point out the interaction point, even young children were able to use the bracelets on their own. In contrast, the QR codes in Courage, Freedom, Love! caused trouble to some guests. Not everyone was able to open them, which caused frustration. The challenges of a possible user error or technical difficulties will be discussed in further detail in chapter 3.6. The QR codes were used by a clear minority of guests, and a spectator could not benefit from someone else opening the content, as it would only be visible on their personal device. This often caused a chain reaction, where one person would stop to open a QR code and people around them would do the same. Especially with a contact point where through a QR code a visitor could see animated characters playing in the snow pictured on the exhibition wall, the person watching would often move with their device, which drew attention.

[250] Lohikoski, interview.

[251] Ibid.

Especially in a smaller space, physical interactive elements can cause challenges, and in some cases, technology can modify the design into a more manageable one, without losing the original element as a whole. Reichstein brough up an example from the first iteration of the exhibition that was shown at the National Museum in 2020-2021. The exhibition had a similar snowy landscape to that currently exhibited in Kotka with the addition of artificial snowballs. Some of them were big, some medium sized, and some were small. The latter proved to be a challenge as the exhibition opened. As it were, the small snowballs were light enough to throw, which led to multiple occurrences of snowball fights within the exhibition space. In the long run this was recognized as too major of a risk by the building management, and the small snowballs were removed from the exhibition. However, the story of a snowball fight now lives on in an animated sequence that can be accessed by a QR code in the snowy room in the newer version of the exhibition shown at the Maritime Museum.

Of course, the animations in Courage, Freedom, Love! are a prime example of a digital solution being used as an extension of the physical space. Making a volcano erupt or having multiple characters throwing a party in a small exhibition space would not be possible in most cases, if it were not done digitally. This brings living characters into the exhibition space that, unlike Moominworld, does not use actors in its storytelling. While interacting with QR codes or watching an animated character does not quite reach the level of explicit interaction, it does bring additional value to the experience. It can be argued that the guest making the choice to stay in the space and explore it for long enough to see one of the rarer animations, such as the volcano, counts as explicit interaction. If seeing the animation alters the way the guest experiences the exhibition and changes the narrative they create around it, the animations can become the exhibition's form of explicit interaction through technology.

Smart phones have become an inseparable part of our lives, so it makes sense that they are becoming visible in themed and immersive spaces. Incorporating mobile media is no longer a choice, as the guests expect it.[252] It is interesting how they simultaneously open possibilities to see spaces otherwise inaccessible or even non-existent, but at the same time risk interrupting the intended flow of the experience and bringing in uncontrollable variables. One of the things to consider when designing modern experience spaces in terms of mobile media is photography. Reichstein mentions discussions on whether photographing would be allowed

[252] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 219.

in the exhibition due to copyright restrictions. In the end, photography was allowed, though Reichstein says that people would have taken pictures in either case, as being able to save memories in digital galleries has become an expectation.[253]

Simultaneously, the photographs that get shared online work as a tool for attractions to receive visibility on social media. Through them new guests can find out about the experience and what it has to offer, which will play a part in the anticipation phase of their future experience. This way they become a part of the poster's experiences participation and reflection phases and potentially influence a future guest's anticipation phase of the same, or related, experience. Each experience is divided into these three phases: anticipation, participation, and reflection.[254] While this thesis mostly discusses actions taken during the anticipation phase, it is important to note that the two others change the way the guests see the space and have an impact on the decision to revisit or visit it in the first place. Through digital platforms, the reflections of others reach potential new guests easily and make feedback more public than it was before.

Overall, different digital solutions can be used to expand the space and add elements that would not be possible to facilitate in the physical environment alone. When used purposefully, they can offer the guests further changes for interaction and personalization and support the storytelling within the experience.[255] Since mobile media will be brought into the space by the guests, it can be the designer's benefit to incorporate it in the design to better control the overall experience.

3.5. In the Realms of Experience

Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love! have partially different goals when it comes to creating an experience. An interesting discussion can be had about their placements on the four realms of an experience by Pine and Gilmore. Both experiences studied in this thesis have been built to offer chances for deep immersion, though Moominworld even more than Courage, Freedom, Love! that still utilizes display cases and exhibition texts to offer further

[253] Reichstein, interview.

[254] Rossman and Duerden, "*Designing Experiences*", 9.

[255] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 152 & 220.

information and context for its guests. These were a later addition to make the experience meaningful for audiences who came to it looking to learn more.[256] Courage, Freedom, Love! also more clearly utilizes art in its theming, which can create the feeling of a human touch.[257] This works well when introducing the guests to the world of Tove Jansson's Moomins, but it does set the exhibition apart from Moominworld, which instead removes the creator from the equation and introduces the guests to the world of Moomins, almost as if they were visiting a new country.

All four realms' presence is needed for a successful experience.[258] Pine and Gilmore summarize the differences between the realms through the guests' expectations: a participant in an educational experience wants to *learn*, in an escapist experience they want to *do*, in an entertainment experience they want to *sense*, and in an esthetic experience they just want to *be* there.[259] The categories are divided by the level of active participation and immersion, as is seen in figure 1 below.

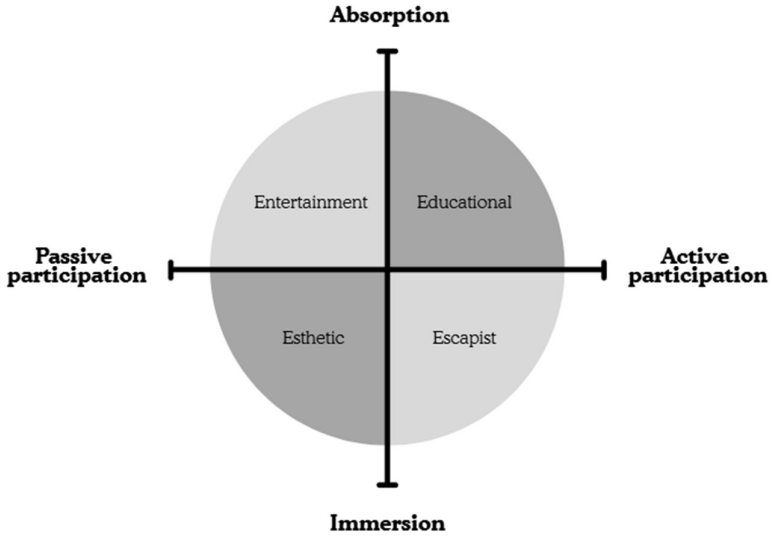


Figure 1 (repeated). The Realms of Experience.

The question of active and passive participation makes this discussion more multifaceted, as the attractions can only offer opportunities for interaction and participation but cannot force

[256] Reichstein, interview.

[257] Lukas, "*The Immersive Worlds Handbook*", 210.

[258] Pine and Gilmore, "*The Experience Economy*," 39.

[259] Ibid., 35.

guests to take them. Pine and Gilmore see active participants as guests who personally affect the experience, while passive participants do not have direct influence or affect over it. Many adults in Moominworld stand by while watching others participate and explore the space further than what can be seen from the sidelines, and some come to Courage, Freedom, Love! specifically to enjoy the displays without the need for more active participation. This gives the experiences an esthetic dimension, as the guests are immersed in the environment, but are not actively influencing the experience.

Although, especially in the case of the display cases, participation cannot be counted as fully passive since the guests are immersed in the larger space around them and need to move from display to display to see into them. They need to actively seek the information to then consume it in a more passive manner. Even in Moominworld where guests may take a break from active exploration and simply observe others, they have still taken the initiative to come to the space and find a place to rest. Pine and Gilmore use an example of a ski race spectator to explain the inescapable activity that is included even in passive experiences. Just by attending the spectator contributes to the visual and aural event that others experience.[260] As was discussed in chapter 3.2., other guests and staff's presence in themed and immersive spaces, similarly to the example's spectator, influence other guests' experience. Therefore, they have an effect on the experience and by definition cannot be fully passive in their physical presence.

The second realm of experience connected to passive participation is entertainment, which Pine and Gilmore describe as guests passively absorbing the experience through their senses, such as in the case of a music performance or traditional theatre.[261] As both Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love! are immersive by nature, such passive absorption can mainly been seen in the theater present in Moominworld, since the stage in Courage, Freedom, Love! requires audience interaction through performance for a show to appear. In these two experiences, watching from the side can hardly be described as merely absorption since the guest remains immersed in the themed physical environment even if they do not feel immersed in the story world it represents.

[260] Ibid., 30.

[261] Ibid., 31.

Similar discussion can be had with the realm of education. Especially Courage, Freedom, Love! offers the guests an opportunity to learn more about Tove Jansson and the Moomins through the display cases and videos presented within them. However, seeing these videos and investigating the content of the cases is not possible from outside of the themed experience site, which keeps the guests surrounded by the world of Moomins. In their definitions of absorption and immersion, Pine and Gilmore state that in the first case the experience goes into the guests and in the latter the guest goes into the experience. Watching television is considered an experience going into the person who is absorbing the content from it. Then again, the guest entering a gallery or a theme park immerses them in it, as they are going into the experience. By this definition, the guests studying the display cases are partaking in an immersive experience, as they have entered the exhibition space to access the experience, though it can be argued that the act of watching a video is a passive micro experience on its own.

Both Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love! are balancing between the realms of education, entertainment, esthetic, and escapist in a way that makes it impossible to fully differentiate between the four. In this case, the experience of learning more about Tove Jansson in the exhibition or the correct way to fold laundry with Mrs Fillyjonk in Moominworld are both examples of educational moments that occur in an immersive environment in a way that makes them entertaining. In both of these experiences, the most present realm of experience is escapist, which includes both greater immersion and active participation.[262] In both Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love! the guests can affect the experience in different ways. In Moominworld they can have conversations with characters or participate in activities, while in Courage, Freedom, Love! they can play with props in the Moominhouse or the theatre stage. Both environments also offer opportunities for free play.

As said, escapism is perhaps the most obvious realm both case studies are present in. At the same time, they have a strong visual presence and offer an environment where the guests can just be, if they so choose. Reichstein describes the exhibition as a place where the guests can experience living like Moomins. This does not necessarily require active participation, as the guests' existence in the world of Moomins can give them the wanted experience. Both Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love! have a strong presence within the esthetic realm,

[262] Ibid., 33.

although they both are immersive by design. While Courage, Freedom, Love! leans more towards the educational, Moominworld has an even stronger presence in the realm of escapism. These do not mean that one experience would be more educational or more immersive than the other, as both experiences have a presence in all four realms. Therefore, the focus shifts to approach and design chosen in terms of each realm.

Balancing the presence in the realms of experience is not completely in the designer's control, as different guests take the space up on different opportunities. For a child who is not as interested in the display cases, Courage, Freedom, Love! becomes a playground, which moves it towards an escapist experience especially, if an adult does not redirect the child's attention to the more passive content. Similarly, a guest visiting Moominworld to learn about Moomins and the surrounding area is more likely to absorb more of the nature and educational details of their environment, and perhaps not as actively participate in the character discussions or stations for interaction. The guest's individual experiences may differ in terms of the realms of the experience, which further emphasizes the individual nature of experiences.

3.6. Creating Curiosity and Managing Expectations

The original assumption at the beginning of this thesis was that Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love! use different visual and auditory cues to prompt their guests to explore the physical environment, and to immerse themselves in the story through interaction. Based on the interviews, this seems to play a smaller role than expected. Instead, both Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love! are relying on the immersion and curiosity of their guests and giving them the choice of engaging, or not.

Both attractions are described as being full of details and things to discover, enough so that most visitors do not notice everything during one visit.[263] Lohikoski says that the theme park sets itself apart from amusement parks specifically by allowing the guests to explore freely without being strictly directed towards specific attractions in set order. Instead, they get to be active participants and choose their paths themselves.[264] The guests get to explore the space in

[263] Lohikoski, interview.; Reichstein, interview.

[264] Lohikoski, interview.

the order and pace they choose in both Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love!. This also means that they most likely will miss things. [265] As Reichstein put it: "There is not any set and clear script of what must be done here. There are just an awful lot of possibilities."[266] He describes the audience's freedom to be based on "guided chance". The path they take can be affected by the placement of display cases and painted pathways.[267] Similar tools are used in Moominworld, where some details may be so low that they will most likely only be spotted by a child.[268]

Guided chance can be affected through blocking.[269] For example, the use of attractors, as discussed in chapter 3.3. or the placement of clearly interactive elements can draw the guests towards them. Still, they do not force the guests to engage directly. In the case of Courage, Freedom, Love!, for example, the Moominhouse in the main room acts as an attractor, but the guests can approach it from many different angles and choose to look at other details on their way to it.[270] Reichstein says his process is affected by memories of what he himself would have wanted to play with. He states that if there are, for example, little boats with comfortable seats in them, people will naturally go sit in them.[271] Objects with clear and familiar function, such as a boat, theatre stage, or a mailbox, work as cues for interaction and offer guidance to what can be done in the space. The costumes available in Courage, Freedom, Love! are a good example of a cue to play that simultaneously offers an alibi for interaction through a clear invitation to play and an opportunity to take on a character. Seeing familiar objects that the guest has positive associations with can help to draw them to explore further.

Encouraging guests to explore generally leads into one of two options: either they are rewarded with a discovery or they get disappointed. These can occur simultaneously in a case where a discovery is made but it seems underwhelming or cannot be fully accessed. An example of this would be the discovery of a chest only to find it to be locked – that initial excitement of having found a treasure falls flat when the reward cannot be accessed. The line

[265] Ibid.; Reichstein, interview.

[266] Reichstein, interview, translated from Finnish to English by the author.

[267] Ibid.

[268] Lohikoski, interview.

[269] Reichstein, interview.

[270] Ibid.

[271] Ibid.

between a satisfactory discovery and disappointment or frustration can be a thin one. The laughter coming from Stinky's cavern can be an effective way to liven up the space but when interpreted as a cue to explore further it can lead to frustration due to further discovery not being possible in the moment. The joy of finally finding the giggling girl on the wall of Courage, Freedom, Love! can be a relieving discovery, but if the guest cannot determine the source of the sound it can turn into annoyance.

Both Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love! had a case of a locked door during the observation. Moominworld has a giant pumpkin that is marked on the map as an attraction but was locked during the observation periods. Based on the website this is not always the case, so in Moominworld's case this seems to have been a temporary situation.[272] Courage, Freedom, Love! has a mailbox that the pathway leading into the room guides the guests past. During the observation phase, many guests tried to open it and some remarked about the disappointment of not being able to see inside of it. While these reactions were mild, it was clear that the mailbox had piqued their curiosity and initiated a need to inspect it further, which in the end did not lead to a discovery, like the guest had anticipated.

The situation with the mailbox gets yet another dimension to it when we take into account the reason behind it being locked. As explained by Reichstein, it was built to facilitate additional activities that could be done around it if the museum so chose. The museum could organize activities where questions, feedback, or letters to Moomins are written and left in the mailbox.[273] However, this was not arranged at least during the observation periods. Without the workshops or the opportunity to independently leave mail, the purpose of the mailbox was left unclear, or interpreted as purely cosmetic. As said, some guests tried opening the box, and couple of them even remarked on it being locked, which showed a level of disappointment or confusion. Nevertheless, this shows that recognizable objects that are already associated with discovery, such as doors and mailboxes, can relatively easily initiate a response as long as they are positioned in a way that does not send a message of a restricted area. This is successfully used in Courage, Freedom, Love! space that has, for example, a tiny door and a handbag that upon discovery can be opened to reveal more props and details referring to the source material.

[272] "The Giant Pumpkin", Moominworld, accessed December 30, 2025, https://www.moominworld.fi/attractions/fairytale-attractions/the-giant-pumpkin/.

[273] Reichstein, interview.

Displaying information behind a door or a latch offers the guest the feeling of discovery and a reward for being active. This is an opportunity to encourage them to continue looking for details, as they have learned that the effort is rewarded.

Discovery does not always have to be behind a door. An instance like this came up during the last minutes of the last observation period in the exhibition, when I noticed a cloud. Up above the guests hanging from the ceiling were two Moomin characters lying flying on clouds, which had gone unnoticed up to the point I happened to look up. This offered a similar sense of discovery and reward, as well as increased the feeling of immersion as the Moomin world truly surrounded me. By considering all directions and not just the ones guests were guided towards and expected to gaze at, the chance of accidental discovery is increased and the immersion becomes stronger. In Moominworld, the nature surrounding the park protects it from a wandering gaze breaking the immersion, as the Moominvalley has similar outdoor scenery. However, in the exhibition, other indoor locations, or experiences with less-suitable surroundings, the addition of built elements in places such as the ceiling can help in making them feel like a part of the fictional world. Simultaneously the addition of better hidden elements works in favor of personalized experiences, as the guests get the feeling of having seen something not everybody discovers, which encourages them to look for more knowing that the space has been intentionally built for it. This gives the guests the cue that further exploration is expected and accepted.

If a precedent is set and the guests learn that peaking behind objects, looking up, or entering smaller spaces to look for details is rewarded, it sets an expectation to be managed. This links back to the discussion of QR codes in Courage, Freedom, Love!. While they prompt interactions and offer an opportunity to discover initially hidden materials and scenes, they can also lead to a frustrating experience where the attempt to explore leads to the guest feeling inadequate. These negative experiences risk being associated with the attempt to find something new and discourage the guest from trying again to avoid feeling frustrated or experiencing failure in using technology. In this, the physical bracelets are more reliable in avoiding negative associations, as they do not require additional skills to use.

The QR codes, for those who can use it, offer an added element of immersion and interactivity that would otherwise not be possible, as was discussed in chapter 3.4. Reichstein

says that they were not a part of the original exhibition in 2020-2021 but were added to the later version of it as the skills to use them had become more common.[274] This consideration of the increased level of the expected skill in using technology is an interesting observation, and certainly a current one for many experience sites. The increase in guests' technology skills creates opportunities that in the future can open new doors for digital interactivity and immersion. Much like we need to focus on managing the guests' expectations for the space, we also need to keep an eye on our own expectations of the guests' capabilities.

In creating opportunities for guests to discover additional details and explore, expectation management in terms of time becomes a key element. The amount of time allocated to the visit by the guests themselves came up in both interviews. Once the expectation has been set that there are a lot of things and details to see, whether through an example, marketing, or accident, the guests are more likely to stay to see what they are expecting. Similarly, if they have not reserved enough time for the visit, they tend to miss more details and opportunities in both Moominworld and Courage, Freedom, Love![275] It seems apparent that the knowledge of not yet having found something is a stronger motivator to explore compared to the abstract possibility of possibly finding something new. However, the observed reactions to the latter one were much stronger, suggesting a different kind of satisfaction. Keeping this in mind, marketing as a tool for encouraging exploration may not be the most effective approach. Although, it can be used to increase the time the guest is planning to spend in the park, which sets the expectation of there being more to see, and offers the possibility to discover things without a rush. Guests with more time in the park are more likely to see things twice, which makes it more probable for the better-hidden, or only sporadically appearing, details to be noticed. Lohikoski also points to marketing as an additional platform for storytelling and evoking emotions, as it is a part of the customers' journey through the experience.[276]

Jenkins discusses the number of elements needed in building embedded narratives in video games. He points out that it is unlikely for one player to recognize the significance of every object they see, hence the information needed to deduce the story of the game needing to be spread out across multiple elements and redundantly presented.[277] While the purpose of the

[274] Ibid.

[275] Ibid.; Lohikoski, interview.

[276] Lohikoski, interview.

[277] Jenkins, "Game Design" 10.

story in a game space is different to that of a theme park or an exhibition, the notion of needing there to be enough of the crucial elements to understand it stays the same.

Achieving an environment that invites the guests to explore and keeps them immersed is not enough. Exploration takes time, and sometimes people have not counted in the minutes or hours they will spend exploring their surroundings and discovering everything that is on offer. Lohikoski recognizes the communication about the time guests should reserve for visiting Moominworld as a key aspect of ensuring opportunities for exploration to take place. She mentions that Moominworld is working to further improve the message they send to their guests about how much time they can expect to spend in the theme park, and how much there really is to see. The island is physically big, and full of details. In fact, both Courage, Freedom, Love! and Moominworld have so many of these details that it is unlikely a single person would spot all of them during one visit, even if they were specifically looking for them.[278]

It is possible, then, that another guest would afterwards post on social media or talk with their friends about a detail, or even a whole micro experience, that someone else has missed. The expectation for how much time should be allocated for a visit is set during the anticipation phase of the experience, when the guest is consuming content and information about the future destination. During this phase they are likely to come across the results of the reflection phases of other guests in the forms of social media posts, reviews and face-to-face conversations. Families may tell one another how much more there would have been to see, and comment on returning later, or even invite others to visit with them.

This signals an abundance of content within the experience. While these guest-to-guest interactions cannot be controlled by the designer, certain elements such as photo walls, feedback surveys, and hashtags can be used to encourage public reflection. These can increase the number of reflections online giving the experience more publicity, but it does mean that negative experiences are more likely to become visible for other potential guests. Even then, the opportunity to learn about the opportunities of the experience beforehand can make a new guest both allocate more time for their visit and stay to look for specific elements they have learned about before physically entering the space.

[278] Lohikoski, interview.; Reichstein, interview.

It was clear that my pre-existing knowledge of Courage, Freedom, Love!'s animations made me spend more time there. Other guests also tipped one another off on different details they had noticed, prompting others to stay longer to experience what someone else had found. Such was especially the case with the rarer animations, such as the volcano erupting, or a specific character passing by in the ocean. The tendency to look for one's favorite character, ever so present in Moominworld, showcased itself in these moments in the ocean room, where a child learned that they could see Snufkin if they just explored the ocean for a little longer.

Moominworld as a space seems, and is, much larger than the exhibition. Naturally, the guest may spend much longer in the park before they feel as if they have seen everything it has to offer, even if many details or interactions have been missed. According to Lohikoski, one can easily spend two days at the park, or even more, yet some groups still only reserve a few hours for their visit.[279] Courage, Freedom, Love! has a much smaller space, and does not offer the endless opportunities of speaking with characters. However, this means that the guests are more focused on the exhibition as a more compact unit, since they are not experiencing the additional stimulation from the forest environment and pathways that Moominworld has.

In Courage, Freedom, Love!, some elements can only be discovered through spending time in the exhibition. Specific animations are timed to appear in certain intervals, some more often than others. These are not specifically marked and can appear in unexpected places, so whether a guest sees one is up to patience, luck, or a tip from another guest. In the ocean room, the animation is on a loop. Many who ended up spending a longer time in the room did so after themselves discovering something exiting passing by in the ocean, while some, especially younger children, were pointed in the right direction by others who had already discovered the traveling characters in the sea. Again, the key to discovery seemed to be to make the audience spend enough time in the room to see the things they really found interesting. The discovery of a familiar character, a loud plane engine, or a thunderstorm prompted many delighted responses from guests, but many turned around from the entrance after glancing over the room. This would make them miss the display cases in the room as

[279] Lohikoski, interview.

they were not visible from the door, as well as any animated details that were not present at that moment.

Part of getting guests immersed and seeking further engagement is driven through providing them with a selection of options and allowing them to determine the value of exploration themselves. Encouraging the guests to allocate enough time to get a satisfactory experience is a part of the work being done to ensure that the options are not just available, but achievable within the timeframe the guests have set. Granted, if the guest chooses to rush through the experience, they may not pay attention to details or pick up on the cues and opportunities. Reichstein compares this to life itself: You can choose to stop and appreciate things, or you can prioritize something else, rush through, and end up missing things you never knew existed.[280]

[280] Reichstein, interview, translated from Finnish to English by the author.

4. Conclusion

Encouraging exploration and engagement in themed and immersive environments starts long before the guest ever enters the space. They have started making assumptions and collecting information about the experience ahead of them the first time they heard of it and will continue to do so until they arrive. This process includes making the important assumption of how much time is needed to experience the entirety of the environment they are visiting. This decision has a large impact on how much they get to explore, and whether they feel satisfied after the experience, or anxious about having missed something important.

The experience is affected by the spatial design, the guest's own expectations and previous knowledge, and the presence of others. It is apparent that one of the strongest ways to affect guests in themed and immersive spaces is to use other people, whether it be staff or other guests from the same or a different party. Actors are a strong tool for inviting the guests to explore the space and engage in the story world through the environment and its habitats. They can offer personalized interactions that highlight the venues as experiences rather than just services. Actors' ability to give secret missions, reveal further details, or introduce places and characters to look for gives the guests clear options to choose from. This can help ease anxiety over choices and enable the guests to discover more of the world without breaking the immersion to google or to ask non-character staff for directions.

The presence of other guests and staff can both help and hinder immersion and the guests' willingness to explore. Alibis for interaction are a key concept in encouraging people to interact with the space around them, especially when it is based on a story world with different social rules compared to the real world around it. To some adults, being with a child offers a strong alibi for play without embarrassment. During the study, other alibis were found in exhibition texts, character-given cues, and guests witnessing others taking part in playful behavior. Alibis for interaction can be used to get past barriers to immersion. However, these two concepts were not always separate. For example, other people can act both as an alibi and a barrier. They can rarely be completely removed, but through alibis for interaction it can become more comfortable to participate in uncommon behaviors with others present, and the group can even partake together. This creates a situation where the majority establishes a new norm for the current situation, making it easier for others to join in.

Especially spaces that target families need to design their experiences in a way that allows all age groups to have something to engage in. For different age demographics to be immersed, the number of opportunities for interaction and discovery need to be even higher and more varied than in spaces meant only for a single age group to enjoy. Guests can be guided towards content intended for them by changing the placement of it. For example, a display case meant for a grown-up guest can be placed higher up than that meant for a child. While not a perfect solution in terms of accessibility, it works for the most common guest. It is apparent that children and adults sometimes work as each other's interaction points. The adults can point out and introduce the children to new objects and ideas, as well as guide them towards points of interaction and clarify design elements' connection to the storyline. At the same time, children can act as a point of connection for adults. As they explore the space and live their life as if they belong to the Moomin world, they become almost like characters themselves. Many adults enjoy taking photographs and playing with the children, which invites them to engage and offers opportunities for immersion through actions taken as a unit with the child.

Creating an environment where the guests are most likely to explore and engage without feeling rushed or bored requires a balance between the amount of allocated time and the amount of content on offer. The guests should be made aware of the number of opportunities so that they know to allocate an appropriate amount of time for experiencing them. The content should be presented in a way that avoids confusion and allows for discovery as a reward for exploration. Locked doors or technical difficulties can discourage further exploration and break immersion. Sometimes logistical needs may contradict with the needs of full immersion or interaction. Functioning logistics are a basic need for immersion to occur, so at times they need to be prioritized. If people start feeling uncomfortable or lost, they will stop being brave, curious and willing to engage.

This means that the physical space the experience is housed in needs to be both functional and safe. Additionally, its theming and signage need to support both immersion and pathfinding within the experience to keep the guests from becoming confused. Spatial storytelling, often multisensory, allows for further immersion into the story world and its characters. Multisensory experiences use different senses in involving the guests through lights, sounds, smells, and other sensory elements. Guests can be guided through the space by using sensory

cues. However, the reactions to them are affected by previous knowledge and associations. In the case of the case studies, the guests' previous knowledge of Moomins and their world became a key, as it changed their reactions and goals. Those who knew to expect to meet a certain character or to wait for a specific animation were guided by these opportunities, which not every guest was aware of. As both case studies were based on a story world that was well-known among many of the guests, the influence of previous knowledge became apparent.

While this thesis focuses on themed and immersive environments built around pre-existing fictional worlds, the findings of the study are relevant for a much larger scope of experiences. Theming, immersion, and interactivity are not tied to a specific medium. While a lot of research has focused on consumer spaces, theme parks, and museums, similar tools can be used at other attractions, events, and material production. Regardless of the institution, understanding alibis for interaction is useful for deeper engagement and lowering the barrier to entry to any experience with interactive elements, materials requiring deep engagement, or an unconventional space. Additionally, the consideration for engagement through different realms of experience and the influence of previous knowledge are important elements in experience design. The inclusion of visually interesting elements that can be admired and appreciated even without extensive knowledge or understanding of the topic can lead to a meaningful experience and a lasting memory prompting further exploration of the topic either during the experience or later. Similarly, offering alibis for interaction can help guests to feel comfortable with exploring new surroundings and activities without fear of embarrassment.

This study has found multiple tools and strategies that can be used in engaging a guest and making them comfortable exploring an experience space. Even then, they cannot be forced to become immersed nor to interact. Experience designers can offer as many opportunities as possible and remove any obstacles that may hinder immersion and engagement. Still, not every guest is going to choose to explore the experience site thoroughly and discover the smaller details. The designers can only do their best to make the opportunities both available and achievable. The final decision is up to the guests.

While this thesis does not solve the issue of multiple interpretations of words such as immersion, it has collected vocabulary from multiple fields and brought them together in a text describing what those things can achieve together. Once the borders and boxes are left behind, the essence of an experience can be discussed through a combination of terminology

from performance, game studies, and design. I hope that this thesis can play its part in combining the expertise that each of these fields have and making future discussions more accessible through opening terminology and showing connections between the different fields of study.

4.1. Possible Future Research

Due to immersion being a strongly individual experience that can only be offered, not forced, it would be useful to carry out a study on this topic from the audience's perspective. While this thesis covers the designers' perspective and intentions, as well as knowledge based on the perception of audience reactions and feedback, it lacks in the representation of the guest truly going through the experience. While this is partly combated by the observation of my own intuitive reactions and the behavior of other guests, the scope is still limited to visible and audible expressions combined with an individual experience.

Studying the role of the guests would open the opportunity to better understand their effect on one another. It came up in this study that children can act as a point of interaction, and that other people's presence changes the level of comfortability people experience, which connects to possible barriers to immersion and further need for alibis for interaction. Due to these observations being conducted over a rather short period of time, they do not yet offer generalizable information about how much these elements truly affect guests' experience and how other people's presence could be utilized in terms of immersion. Recognizing the moments where other guests cause barriers to immersion would make it possible to address these situations directly to combat them.

Furthermore, it would be valuable to research the role of an actor as a guide to immersion. They can communicate social rules within the fictional worlds they work as a part of, provide alibis for interaction, and through these actions remove barriers to immersion. Their ability to directly engage the guests in a conversation or an action puts them in a position of power in relation to providing opportunities for personalization and creating memories connected to the experience. To further understand the different roles they take on, as well as the current resources they have in terms of training, support, and direction, would help in developing

stronger experiences as well as safer and more efficient work environments within immersive experiences.

Lastly, an interesting viewpoint for further research on this topic would be investigating how guests explore a space they have been in before. If the experience is meaningful enough to receive returning guests, it would be important to understand how they see the space, what they are looking for, and how they can be engaged and introduced to new experiences within a space that is familiar to them. This could result in designs that guests wish to return to frequently to make more of the meaningful memories that made them return the first time.

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6. List of Figures

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2. Alexander Reichstein, The Bridge in Courage, Freedom, Love!

3. Moominworld, Moomin - a fur-character - in front of the Moominhouse, image provided by Ida-Maria Lohikoski.

4. Moominworld, Snufkin - a speaking character – in his camp, image provided by Ida-Maria Lohikoski.

5. Lukas Jokilehto, The Bridge to Moominworld, 2025.

6. Alexander Reichstein, The First Room of Courage, Freedom, Love!

7. Moominworld, Map of Moominworld, image provided by Ida-Maria Lohikoski.

8. Alexander Reichstein, Illustration of Courage, Freedom, Love!'s first iteration that was exhibited at the National Museum of Finland in 2020-2021.

9. Alexander Reichstein, Illustration of Courage, Freedom, Love!'s second iteration that opened at the Maritime Museum of Finland in 2025.

10. Alexander Reichstein, A Display Case in Courage, Freedom, Love!.

11. Alexander Reichstein, Moominmamma's Handbag in Courage, Freedom, Love!.

12. Alexander Reichstein, The Lighthouse Island in the Ocean Room of Courage, Freedom, Love!.

7. Appendix

Topics of discussion

These are the pre-planned main topics for each interview. The interviews were based on these topics, and then guided by the conversation, and the answers given by the interviewees.

Lohikoski:

1. How the Moomin values guide the park's design and operations?
2. Multisensory elements within Moominworld
3. The use of wristbands and other technology in Moominworld
4. Pathfinding within Moominworld
5. The use of attractions that were built as clear points for interaction
6. The use of in-character staff, and how they can prompt the guests to explore
7. Personalizing the experience
8. Are the guests guided towards discoveries, and if so, how?
9. How adult guests experience Moominworld and how it is designed for them
10. What she hopes the guests to experience or find in Moominworld?

Reichstein:

1. How were the design choices for the exhibition made?
2. Multisensory elements within the exhibition
3. The use of QR codes in the exhibition
4. How the display cases function as a part of the exhibition design
5. The use of elements that were built as clear points for interaction
6. Pathfinding within the exhibition
7. Differences between the first iteration of the exhibition in the National Museum, and the current one in the Maritime Museum
8. How the space works for both children and adults
9. Are the guests guided towards discoveries, and if so, how?
10. What he hopes the guests experience or find in the exhibition?

Glossary

Alibi for Interaction = A social rule, physical object or situation that allows someone to try a new behavior or an experience or to initiate an interaction [281]

Anticipation Phase = The phase of an experience before the guest enters it. During this phase the guest gathers information and makes decisions and assumptions about the upcoming experience, including the decision on which experience to attend.[282]

Barrier to Immersion = An element, whether physical, mental, or social, that prevents an individual from feeling immersed

Diegetic Signage = Signage that could genuinely appear in the story world. For example, the sign for the Ollivanders Shop within a Harry Potter themed attraction.[283]

Embedded Narrative = Stories and worldbuilding that have been included in a space in a way that allows a person entering it to piece them together through discovering clues, actions, and opportunities embedded in the environment.[284]

Enacting Stories = A narrative progressing through the player's, or in this thesis' context the guest's, movement across an area [285]

Evocative Spaces = Spaces that allow the player, or in this thesis' context a guest, to interpret a space built around a familiar story by reading it against their pre-existing knowledge and associations [286]

Experience = A memorable event that engages each individual in an inherently personal way, and that the individuals themselves are aware of and deliberately taking part in. See chapter 2.1.1. for further discussion.

Extra-Diegetic Signage = Signage that would not appear in the story world in content nor design.[287]

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[281] *Koljonen, "Introduction to Narrative Experience Design," at 16:05.*

[282] *Rossman and Duerden, "Designing Experiences", 11.*

[283] Younger, "*Theme Park Design*", 206.

[284] *Jenkins, "Game Design", 10-12.*

[285] *Ibid., 8.*

[286] *Ibid., 6-7.*

[287] Younger, "*Theme Park Design*", 206.

Immersion = The feeling of being surrounded by something or becoming absorbed by an interest or a situation.[288] See chapter 2.1.2 for further discussion.

LARP/Live Action Role Play = A game in which players dress as particular characters and act out their roles in the game [289]

Magic Circle = A chosen place and time where an experience is separated from the rest of the world. Inside the limits of the circle, the social rules and consequences to certain actions are different from those of the outside world [290]

Participation Phase = The phase of an experience taking place during it, including all interactions, positive encounters, and any difficulties faced during the experience.[291]

Ractor = An interactive actor performing a non-player-character within a live action roleplay.[292]

Reflection Phase = The phase of an experience after the guest leaves and starts reflecting on the experience. During this phase the perceived results of the experience will influence the guest's perception of the overall experience. This includes looking back on memories and discussing the experience with others.[293]

Semi-Diegetic Signage = Signage displaying extra-diegetic content through signage that could have been made by the story worlds residents with the materials available in their world.[294]

Theming = Using an overarching theme or a concept across a space to organize it [295] See chapter 2.1.2 for further discussion of the definition.

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[288] *Lukas, "The Immersive Worlds Handbook", 4.*

[289] *Cambridge Dictionary, "LARP," accessed December 30, 2025, https://dictionary.cambridge.org/dictionary/english/larp.*

[290] *Koljonen, "Introducing Alibis for Interaction", at 05:40.*

[291] *Rossman and Duerden, "Designing Experiences", 11-12.*

[292] Stenros, "Between Game Facilitation and Performance", 76.

[293] *Rossman and Duerden, "Designing Experiences", 12.*

[294] Younger, "*Theme Park Design*", 206.

[295] *Lukas, "The Immersive Worlds Handbook", 68.*

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